



BACKPACKING SOUTH AFRICA - HOSTEL GUIDE

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BACKPACKING SOUTH AFRICA

South Africa offers diverse experiences—from mountain sunrises to wildlife safaris—at a significantly lower cost than Europe. The country is home to 62 million people, three capital cities, and eleven official languages, though English is widely spoken. While the weather varies by region, it is generally favorable year-round, with dry winters being ideal for safaris. For international travelers, the Rand's current weakness provides excellent value, offering high-quality experiences for a relatively small budget.

In 2026, a South African backpacking trip remains high-value, with dorms costing €8–€18 and private rooms ranging from €25–€60. While food and drink are

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affordable—with restaurant meals under €15 and local beers around €2—activities like safaris, bungee jumping, and shark diving are the primary expenses and should be budgeted for.

Transportation requires planning: the Baz Bus offers a safe, social hop-on-hop-off service along the coast; mainline buses are better for long-distance city runs; and car hire (approx. €20–€35/day) provides the most freedom for remote areas, provided drivers avoid rural roads at night.

Daily budgets typically fall into three tiers:

Budget: €35–€50

Mid-range: €55–€80

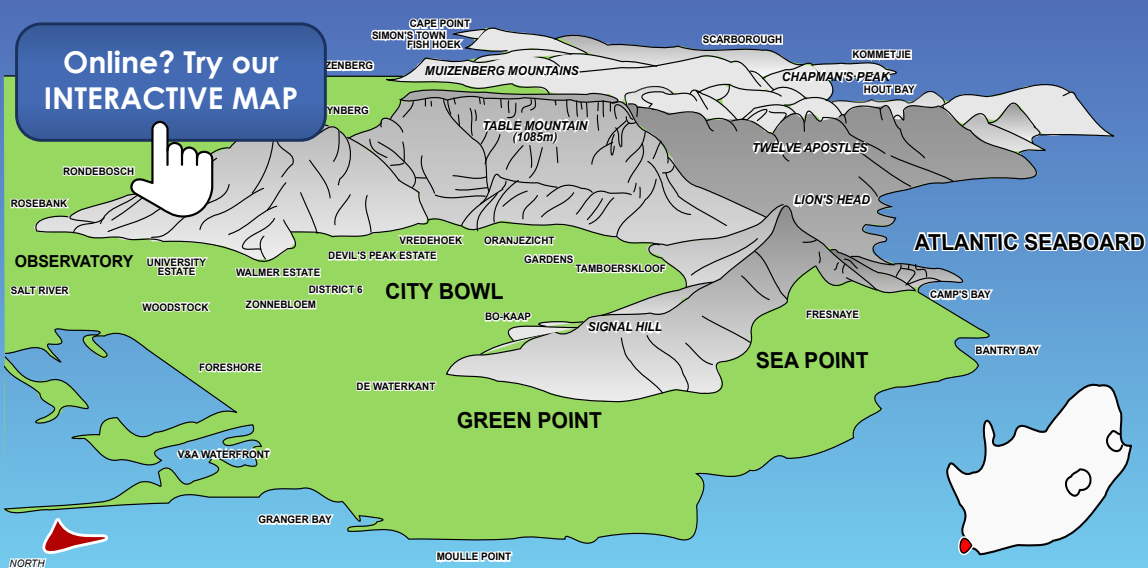
Flashpacker: €80–€120+

Regarding safety, while crime is a reality, most travellers have trouble-free trips by following basic rules: use Uber after dark in cities, avoid walking in unknown areas at night, keep phones out of sight, and utilize hostel safes. Awareness and following local advice are key to a successful visit.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking South Africa](#)



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BACKPACKING CAPE TOWN

Cape Town's scale is impossible to capture in photographs. Dominated by the 1,000-metre-high Table Mountain, the city feels like a vast amphitheatre carved between sandstone peaks and two converging oceans. The Atlantic side offers freezing, turquoise waters and mountain coves, while the False Bay side features warmer water and penguin colonies. This geographic drama creates a sense of disorientation and aliveness that defines the Cape Town experience.

History and Culture

Originally inhabited by the Khoisan, the Cape became a Dutch victualling station in 1652. What began as a simple vegetable patch evolved into a colony built on the labour of enslaved people from across Africa and Asia. This history created the city's unique "Cape Malay" identity, famous today for the vibrant Bo-Kaap district and a distinctive, spiced cuisine. The local dialect is equally hybrid, blending English and Afrikaans into a colourful, expressive vernacular.

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City Geography and Lifestyle

The city is divided into distinct zones:

The City Bowl: The urban heart, home to the nightlife of Long and Kloof Streets.

The Atlantic Seaboard: A glamorous stretch of beaches perfect for sunsets.

Observatory (“Obs”): The bohemian, creative hub with affordable bars and live music.

The South: Surfing hotspots like Muizenberg and the naval history of Simon’s Town.

The local music scene is thriving and influential, led by home-grown genres like Amapiano and Gqom, which have transitioned from township dance floors to global pop charts.

Social Reality and Inequality

Cape Town is a city of stark contrasts, where extreme wealth sits alongside informal settlements. The text advises visitors not to look away from this inequality but to engage with it through respect and attention. Practical support involves tipping well and choosing community-based tour operators rather than large commercial firms.

Backpacker Essentials

Best Time to Visit: Summer (December–March) is peak season, while the shoulder months (October–November



and March–April) offer lower prices and fewer crowds.

Budget: The city is highly affordable for those using pounds or euros. Accommodation, dining, and transport (via Uber or the MyCiTi bus) represent excellent value.

Safety: While violent crime exists, it is manageable with street smarts. The primary risk is opportunistic phone snatching. Visitors are advised to stay off isolated mountain trails alone, avoid walking Long Street after midnight, and use Uber for all nocturnal travel.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Cape Town](#)



CAPE TOWN HOSTELS

CITY BOWL

- [CURIOCITY KLOOF STREET](#)
- [LONG STREET BACKPACKERS](#)
- [ASHANTI LODGE GARDENS](#)
- [URBAN HIVE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [VILLA VIVA CAPE TOWN](#)
- [ANZAC BACKPACKERS \(STAGS HEAD INN\)](#)
- [91 LOOP BOUTIQUE HOSTEL](#)
- [FORTY 8 BACKPACKERS](#)
- [TWO OCEANS](#)
- [ZEBRA CROSSING BACKPACKER LODGE](#)
- [BOKAAP BACKPACKERS](#)

GREEN POINT / SEA POINT

- [CURIOCITY GREEN POINT](#)
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CAPE TOWN HOSTELS *(Continued)*

- [HOUSE ON THE HILL](#)
- [NEVER@HOME CAPE TOWN](#)
- [A SUNFLOWER STOP BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MOJO HOTEL](#)

OBSERVATORY / WOODSTOCK

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- [AFRICAN SOUL SURFER BACKPACKERS](#)
- [LIGHTHOUSE FARM BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)



CURIOCITY KLOOF STREET

STREET ADDRESS: 112 Kloof Street, Gardens, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93435,18.4069](#)

PHONE: [+27 10 590 0210](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 60 488 4746](#)

EMAIL: stay@curiocity.africa

WEBSITE: curiocity.africa

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Luxe Dorms (Mixed and Female-only with en-suite kitchenettes and bathrooms), Standard Doubles, Deluxe Suites, Family Apartments.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range. Dorm beds ~R350–R585; Private rooms ~R1,200–R2,100.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.7 / 10 ("Superb")



LONG STREET BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 209 Long St, Cape Town City Centre, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92526,18.4165](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 423 0615](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 21 423 0615](#)

EMAIL: reservations@longstreetbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: longstreetbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories (mixed), Single and Double/Twin private rooms. All with shared bathrooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R180–R280; private rooms from ~R550–R850.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.1 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")



ASHANTI LODGE GARDENS

STREET ADDRESS: 11 Hof St, Gardens, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93347,18.41216](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 423 8721](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 459 2602](#)

EMAIL: info@ashanti.co.za

WEBSITE: ashanti.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed and private dorms, private rooms (single, double, twin). Shared bathrooms in dorm section; some private rooms en-suite. PIN-code access to gate and rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R220–R380; private rooms from ~R700–R1,200.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.1 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.9 / 10 ("Fabulous")

HOSTEL LIST

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URBAN HIVE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 208 Long St, Cape Town City Centre, 8000

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92565,18.41541](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 422 0565](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 601 2289](#)

EMAIL: info@urbanhivebackpackers.com

WEBSITE: urbanhivebackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed dormitories, female-only dormitories, private double rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R200–R320.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.1 / 10 ("Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~7.4 / 10 ("Very Good")



VILLA VIVA CAPE TOWN

STREET ADDRESS: 74 New Church St, Tamboerskloof, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92714,18.41038](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 423 4530](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: stay@villaviva-capetown.com

WEBSITE: villaviva-capetown.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, private rooms. Focus on creative and social entrepreneurship community.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R250–R380.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.3 / 10 ("Superb")



STAGS HEAD INN (ANZAC BACKPACKERS)

STREET ADDRESS: 71 Hope Street Gardens, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93003,18.41916](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 465 1325](#) / [+27 72 263 3256](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@stagshead.co.za

WEBSITE: stagshead.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms.
Above the Stags Head pub.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. One of the lowest-cost dorm options in the CBD. Dorm beds from ~R160–R250.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

HOSTELWORLD RATING: N/A



91 LOOP BOUTIQUE HOSTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 91 Loop Street, Cape Town City Centre, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92211,18.41854](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 286 1469](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: hello@91loop.co.za

WEBSITE: 91loop.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed dorms, female-only dorms, pod-style capsule dorms (with individual privacy screens), private en-suite rooms. All modern, freshly renovated.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R290–R450; private rooms from ~R900–R1,500.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.6 / 10 ("Fabulous")

HOSTEL LIST

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: CITY BOWL

City: CAPE TOWN

FORTY 8 BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 48 Hout Street, Cape Town City Centre, 8000

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92169,18.4205](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 422 4848](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 21 422 4848](#)

EMAIL: info@forty8backpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: forty8backpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms in a Victorian terraced house.

PRICE RANGE: **Budget.** Dorm beds from ~R180–R300.

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.6 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

HOSTEL LIST



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TWO OCEANS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 47 Long Street, Cape Town City Centre, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.9213,18.4205](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 422 5401](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms in a Victorian guesthouse setting.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R200–R320.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A



ZEBRA CROSSING BACKPACKER LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 82 New Church Street, Tamboerskloof, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.92751,18.41012](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 422 1265](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 601 7041](#)

EMAIL: info@zebracrossingbp.com

WEBSITE: zebracrossingbp.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, private rooms (singles and doubles), and a garden cottage.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R220–R340.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.7 / 10 ("Fabulous")

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BOKAAP BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 5 Carl St, Schotsche Kloof, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.91835,18.41347](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 424 0071](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@bokaapbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: bokaapbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms in the historic Bo-Kaap neighbourhood.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R200–R320.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.8 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

HOSTELWORLD RATING: N/A



CURIOCITY GREEN POINT

STREET ADDRESS: 153 Main Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.9078,18.40638](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 433 4310](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 66 352 4511](#)

EMAIL: greenpoint@curiocity.africa

WEBSITE: curiocity.africa

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Premium Deluxe rooms, Shared Suites (dorm-style), family rooms. All designed to the CURIOCITY aesthetic standard.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range to upper-mid. Shared suites from ~R400–R650; private rooms from ~R1,400–R2,400.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.6 / 10 ("Fabulous")

HOSTEL LIST

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BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: WESTERN CAPE

GREEN POINT / SEA POINT

City: CAPE TOWN

B.I.G: BACKPACKERS IN GREEN POINT

STREET ADDRESS: 18 Thornhill Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.91031,18.40929](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 434 0688](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 494 2197](#)

EMAIL: info@bigbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: bigbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Newly renovated en-suite private rooms and dorms. All styled by professional interior designers; all with private bathrooms.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range to upper-mid. Dorm beds from ~R380–R580; private rooms from ~R1,100–R1,900. Free breakfast included.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.2 / 10 ("Wonderful")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.7 / 10 ("Superb")

HOSTEL LIST

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BIG BLUE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 7 Vesperdene Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.91048,18.41265](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 439 0807](#) / [+27 21 439 8068](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: big.blue@mweb.co.za

WEBSITE: bigblue.za.net

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, private rooms (some en-suite), in a large Victorian mansion. TGCSA 4-star rated lodge.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R250–R420; private rooms from ~R800–R1,400.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.1 / 10 ("Fabulous")



ATLANTIC POINT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 2 Cavalcade Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.90959,18.41165](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 433 1663](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 812 6006](#)

EMAIL: info@atlanticpoint.co.za

WEBSITE: atlanticpoint.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms (singles and doubles). Garden and pool.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R210–R340.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

HOSTELWORLD RATING: N/A



Province: WESTERN CAPE

GREEN POINT / SEA POINT

City: CAPE TOWN

HOUSE ON THE HILL

STREET ADDRESS: 5 Norman Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.90889,18.41067](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 439 3902](#) / [+27 73 217 3428](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 73 217 3428](#)

EMAIL: info@houseonthehillct.co.za

WEBSITE: houseonthehillct.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms in a residential property on the slopes between Signal Hill and Sea Point.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R200–R320.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.4 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: -

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NEVER@HOME CAPE TOWN

STREET ADDRESS: 107 Main Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.90777,18.40917](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 434 9282](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@neverathomeworld.com

WEBSITE: neverathomeworld.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Modern dorms and private rooms. Contemporary design. Both properties aimed at the active, social backpacker market.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R320–R480; private rooms from ~R900–R1,600.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Excellent")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.4 / 10 ("Superb")



A SUNFLOWER STOP BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 179 Main Rd, Green Point, Cape Town, 8005

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.90791,18.40397](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 434 6535](#) / [+27 21 201 8901](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 64 610 8479](#)

EMAIL: info@sunflowerstop.co.za

WEBSITE: sunflowerstop.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, private rooms, and a unique terrace hammock room. Sea Point location on Main Road.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R200–R320.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.6 / 10 ("Excellent")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.3 / 10 ("Superb")

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MOJO HOTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 30 Regent Rd, Sea Point, Cape Town, 8060

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.91916,18.38615](#)

PHONE: [+27 87 940 7474](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 239 4951](#)

EMAIL: reservations@themojohotel.com

WEBSITE: themojohotel.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Hybrid Hotel (Mixed Dorms/ Pods, "Crash Pads," and Private Studios/Suites).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range to upper. Dorm beds from ~R400–R600; private rooms from ~R1,400–R2,800.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.4 / 10 ("Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.0 / 10 ("Fabulous")



GREEN ELEPHANT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 57 Milton Rd, Observatory, Cape Town, 7925

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93793,18.46531](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 448 6359](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 21 448 6359](#)

EMAIL: stay@greenelephant.co.za

WEBSITE: greenelephant.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories (mixed and female-only), private rooms, long-stay flats. Three houses. Observatory, Cape Town's most bohemian suburb.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R180–R280. Long-stay monthly rates also available.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.3 / 10 ("Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~6.9 / 10 ("Good")

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AFRICAN HEART BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 27 Station Rd, Observatory, Cape Town, 7925

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93883,18.46689](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 447 9225](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 805 7984](#)

EMAIL: info@africanheartbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: africanheartbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms. Small, intimate hostel in the Observatory neighbourhood.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R160–R260.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A



BOHEMIAN LOFTS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 41 Trill Road (corner of Lower Main Road), Observatory, Cape Town, 7925

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93916,18.46891](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 447 6204](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@bohemianlofts.com

WEBSITE: bohemianlofts.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Loft-style dormitories and private rooms. Observatory, in a converted residential property.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R170–R280.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A



RIVERLODGE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 80 Alexandra Rd, Oude Molen Village, Pinelands, Cape Town, 7405

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93947,18.48957](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 448 0526](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 515 0407](#)

EMAIL: info@riverlodge.co.za

WEBSITE: riverlodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Large hostel aimed at group travellers, sports tours, school groups, construction company accommodation, and budget solo travellers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R160–R240. The lowest price point on this list.

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.6 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~7.1 / 10 ("Very Good")



HOUT BAY DUNE LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Corner of Harbour Road & North Shore Drive, Hout Bay, Cape Town, 7806

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.04543,18.34946](#)

PHONE: [+27 79 267 9472](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 267 9472](#)

EMAIL: bookings@dunelodge.co.za

WEBSITE: dunelodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Private rooms, 4-bed and 6-bed dormitories (all en-suite), in Hout Bay village. Garden and mountain setting. Walking distance from the beach, harbour, and World of Birds.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R260–R380; private rooms from ~R780–R1,200.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.6 / 10 ("Excellent")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~9.1 / 10 ("Superb")



SALTYCRAX BACKPACKERS AND ADVENTURES

STREET ADDRESS: 20 Briza Rd, Table View, Cape Town, 7439

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.82109,18.48276](#)

PHONE: [+27 66 437 7801](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 66 437 7801](#)

EMAIL: info@saltycrax.com

WEBSITE: saltycrax.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed dorms, double rooms, triple rooms, family rooms (some en-suite). TGCSA 5-star graded hoxel.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range. Dorm beds from ~R220–R350; private rooms from ~R700–R1,300.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 ("Very Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~5.6 / 10

HOSTEL LIST

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BLOUBERG BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 10 Marine Circle, Bloubergrant, Cape Town, 7441

GOOGLE MAPS [-33.8219,18.49296](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 556 2262](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 458 5581](#)

EMAIL: info@bloubergbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: bloubergbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf & Adventure Hostel (Mixed Dorms, Female Dorms, and Private En-suite Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R750 (~\$40).



AFRICAN SOUL SURFER BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Surfers Corner, 13 York Road, Muizenberg, Cape Town, 7945

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.10792,18.4691](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 788 1771](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 805 7984](#)

EMAIL: info@aficansoulsurfer.co.za

WEBSITE: aficansoulsurfer.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories and private rooms, many with direct ocean/Surfers' Corner views and private balconies.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R250–R380; sea-view private rooms from ~R700–R1,200.

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.6 / 10 ("Good")



LIGHTHOUSE FARM BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: A1 Oude Molen Eco Village, Alexandra Road, Pinelands, Cape Town, 7700

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93755,18.48803](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 447 9165](#) / [+27 21 447 9177](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 744 2504](#)

EMAIL: bookings@lighthousefarm.co.za

WEBSITE: lighthousefarm.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories (quad bunk rooms with Oregon pine floors) and double rooms. Set within the Oude Molen Eco Village.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from ~R170–R270.

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.6 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.1 / 10 ("Good")

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~6.0 / 10 ("Good")



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BACKPACKING THE CAPE WINELANDS

The Cape Winelands, comprising the Stellenbosch, Franschhoek, and Paarl triangle, is a premier South African destination known for its dramatic mountain scenery, world-class viticulture, and exceptional value for travellers.

The Three Hubs

Stellenbosch: A vibrant university town with historic architecture and active nightlife. It is the most practical base for those without a car, as it is walkable and connected to Cape Town by train.

Franschhoek: A picturesque valley village with a French Huguenot heritage. While it is an elite culinary destination, budget travellers can utilise the Wine Tram and

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local markets.

Paarl: A less touristic, “working” town that offers more affordable access to surrounding farms and serves as a gateway to the north and east.

Backpacker Essentials

Transport: While Stellenbosch is accessible by train and Baz Bus, exploring Franschhoek and Paarl generally requires a hire car or specific planning. Because of strict drink-driving laws (0.05% limit), travellers are encouraged to use the Wine Tram or organised hostel tours.

Wine & Dining: Tasting fees at estates are typically R100–R200. Buying wine directly from cellar doors is significantly cheaper than in cities or restaurants.

Safety: The region is generally safer than Cape Town. Town centres are walkable with standard awareness, and hiking trails like those in Jonkershoek are well-used and safe for solo trekkers.

Best Times to Visit

Harvest (Jan–March): The peak experience for wine lovers, though temperatures can exceed 35°C.

Shoulder Season (Oct–Nov): Ideal weather and fewer crowds.

Winter (June–Aug): Quiet and atmospheric, featuring fireside tastings and empty trails.

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CAPE WINELANDS HOSTELS

PAARL

- [PAARL BACKPACKERS](#)

STELLENBOSCH

- [STUMBLE INN](#)

FRANSCHHOEK

- [OTTERS BEND LODGE](#)

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: WINELANDS

Town: PAARL

PAARL BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 40 Du Toit Street, Esterville, Paarl, 7646

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.74447,18.96157](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 736 3410](#) / [+27 21 201 8901](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 736 3410](#)

EMAIL: paarlbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: paarlbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.1 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Guesthouse/Hostel
(Dormitories and Private Family Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R600 (~\$32).

HOSTEL LIST



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STUMBLE INN BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 12 Market Street, Stellenbosch Central, Stellenbosch, 7600

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.93885,18.85505](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 887 4049](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 805 7984](#)

EMAIL: info@stumble-inn.co.za

WEBSITE: stumble-inn.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.9 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Classic Backpacker Lodge (Mixed Dorms, Female-only Dorms, Private En-suite/ Shared Rooms, and Camping sites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R750 (~\$40).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: WINELANDS

Town: FRANSCHHOEK

OTTER'S BEND LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Dassenberg Rd, Franschhoek, 7690

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.91117,19.1098](#)

PHONE: [+27 64 872 3501](#) / [+27 21 876 3200](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 64 872 3501](#)

EMAIL: info@ottersbendlodge.co.za

WEBSITE: ottersbendlodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Rustic Eco-Lodge & Farm-stay (En-suite Log Cabins, Family Cabins, and Boutique Campsites).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range Budget. Campsites from R400 (~\$22); Double/Twin En-suite rooms from R900 (~\$48); Family Cabins from R1,500 (~\$80).

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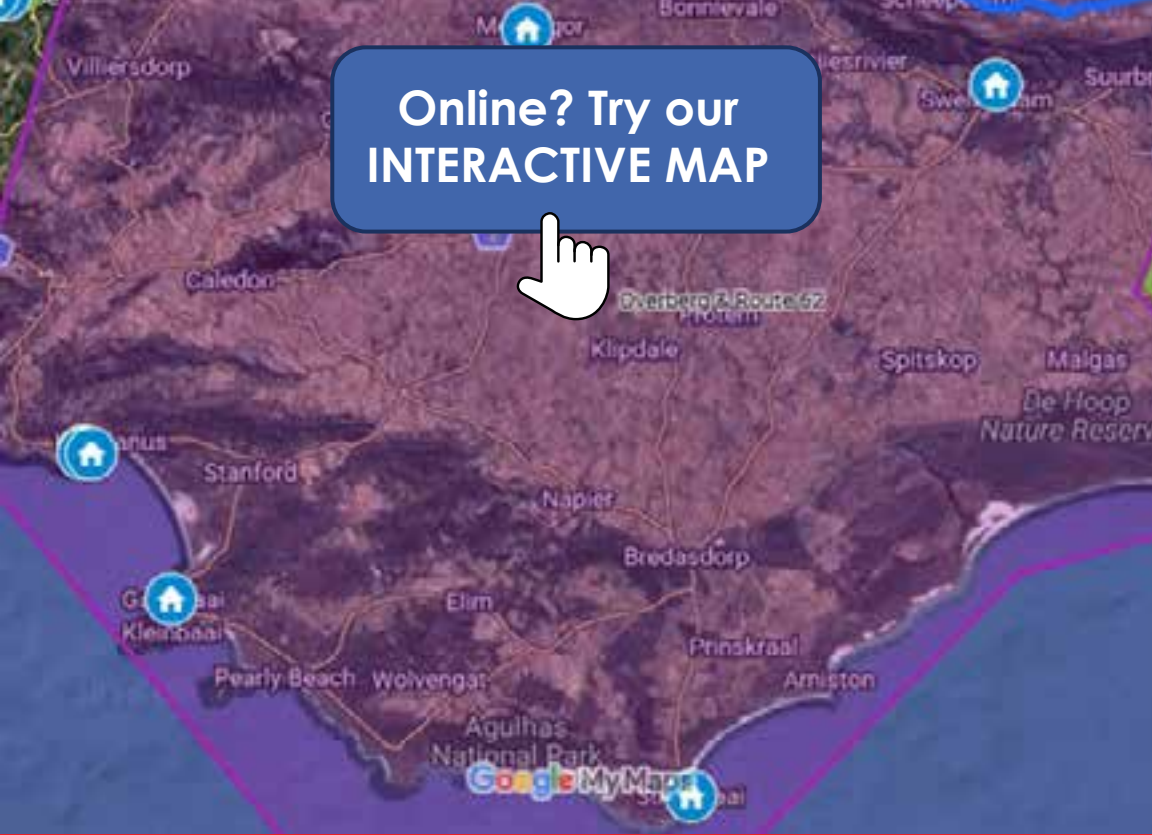
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BACKPACKING THE OVERBERG

The Overberg, or “Over the Mountain,” is a region of quiet magnificence located just beyond the Hottentots Holland range from Cape Town. It is defined by its diverse landscapes, ranging from the apple orchards of the Elgin Valley and the golden wheat fields of the interior to a dramatic coastline where the Atlantic and Indian Oceans officially meet.

Natural Highlights and Wildlife

Whale Watching: The region is a premier global stronghold for southern right whales, which migrate from Antarctica to calve in the warm shallows between June and December. Hermanus offers world-renowned, free land-based viewing from its cliff paths, particularly during the September–October peak.

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Biodiversity: A core part of the Cape Floristic Region, the Overberg boasts incredible plant diversity, especially within the De Hoop Nature Reserve. It is also a critical habitat for the endangered blue crane.

The Meeting of Oceans: Cape Agulhas marks the southernmost tip of Africa and the official dividing line between two major ocean currents, creating rich fishing grounds and a unique marine environment.

Practical Information for Backpackers

Transport: A hire car is essential. The region is not served by the Baz Bus or reliable public transport. Driving offers the benefit of experiencing Clarence Drive, one of the country's most scenic coastal routes.

Timing: September and October are the "sweet spots," combining peak whale activity with the spring wildflower bloom. December to February is best for beach weather, while winter offers a quieter, atmospheric experience.

Costs: Generally affordable, with a daily budget of €40–€65 covering essentials. While Hermanus has more guesthouses than traditional hostels, dorm beds are available for approximately €10–€18.

Activities: Key attractions include land-based whale watching (free), boat-based sea safaris, shark cage diving in Gansbaai, and trekking the famous Whale Trail.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking The Overberg](#)

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OVERBERG HOSTELS

HERMANUS

- [ZZZONE BOUTIQUE HOSTEL](#)
- [HERMANUS BACKPACKERS](#)
- [ZOETE INVAL TRAVELLERS LODGE](#)

GANSBAAI

- [GANSBAAI LODGE & BACKPACKERS](#)

STRUISBAAI

- [CAPE AGULHAS BACKPACKERS](#)

WITSAND

- [WITSAND POSHPACKERS](#)



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: OVERBERG

Town: HERMANUS

ZZZONE BOUTIQUE HOSTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 4 Harbour Road, Warrington Place, Hermanus, 7200

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.42092,19.24206](#)

PHONE: [+27 28 312 1799](#) / [+27 21 430 4000](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 118 7554](#)

EMAIL: bookings@zzzone.co.za

WEBSITE: zzzone.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.1 / 10 "Wonderful"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique "Sleep-Centric" Hostel (Mixed Dorms, Female-only Dorms, and Private Twin Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range Budget. Dorm beds from R375 (~\$20); Private rooms from R800 (~\$43).

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: OVERBERG

Town: HERMANUS

ZOETE INVAL TRAVELLERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 23 Main Road, Hermanus, 7200, Western Cape, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.41886,19.23054](#)

PHONE: [+27 28 312 1242](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 78 583 4101](#)

EMAIL: zoetein@hermanus.co.za

WEBSITE: zoeteinval.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars (Based on long-standing guest feedback as of 2026)

BOOKING.COM RATING: 8.0 / 10 "Very Good" (Verified active listing for February 2026).

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Conscious Travellers Lodge (Mixed & Female Dormitories, Standard Rooms, Family Suites, and Self-Catering Loft Apartments)

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HERMANUS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 26 Flower St, Hermanus, 7200

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.42068,19.23279](#)

PHONE: [+27 28 312 4293](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: backpackers@whalemail.co.za

WEBSITE: hermanusbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 9.0 / 10 "Wonderful"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Lodge & Hostel (Mixed Dorms, En-suite Privates, and self-contained Family Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R295 (~\$16); Private doubles from R845 (\$45); Family units with kitchens from R1,400 (~\$75).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: OVERBERG

Town: GANSBAAI

GANSBAAI LODGE & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 6 Strand St, Gansbaai, 7220

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.58148,19.34848](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 626 4150](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 626 4150](#)

EMAIL: info@gansbaybackpackers.com

WEBSITE: gansbaybackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Adventure Lodge & Youth Hostel (Mixed Dorms, En-suite Family Rooms, Private Double/Twin Rooms, and Garden Studio Suites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R260 (~\$14); Private doubles from R500 (~\$27); En-suite Family rooms from R600 (~\$32).

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: OVERBERG

Town: STRUISBAAI

CAPE AGULHAS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 17 Duiker St, Struis Bay, Struisbaai, 7285

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.79837,20.04618](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 372 3354](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 372 3354](#)

EMAIL: info@capeagulhasbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: capeagulhasbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 8.6 / 10 "Fabulous"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Adventure Hostel
(Mixed Dorms, Female-only Dorms, Private En-suite Rooms, and Camping/Overland sites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R650 (~\$35).

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: OVERBERG

Town: WITSAND

WITSAND POSHPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 89 Main Rd, Witsand, 6666

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.39303,20.83729](#)

PHONE: [+27 28 537 1717](#) | [+27 82 850 4318](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 850 4318](#)

EMAIL: accom@witsand.co.za

WEBSITE: witsand.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Adventure Lodge
(Upmarket Dorms, Family Rooms, and Private Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R280 (\$15); Private rooms from R850 (~\$45).

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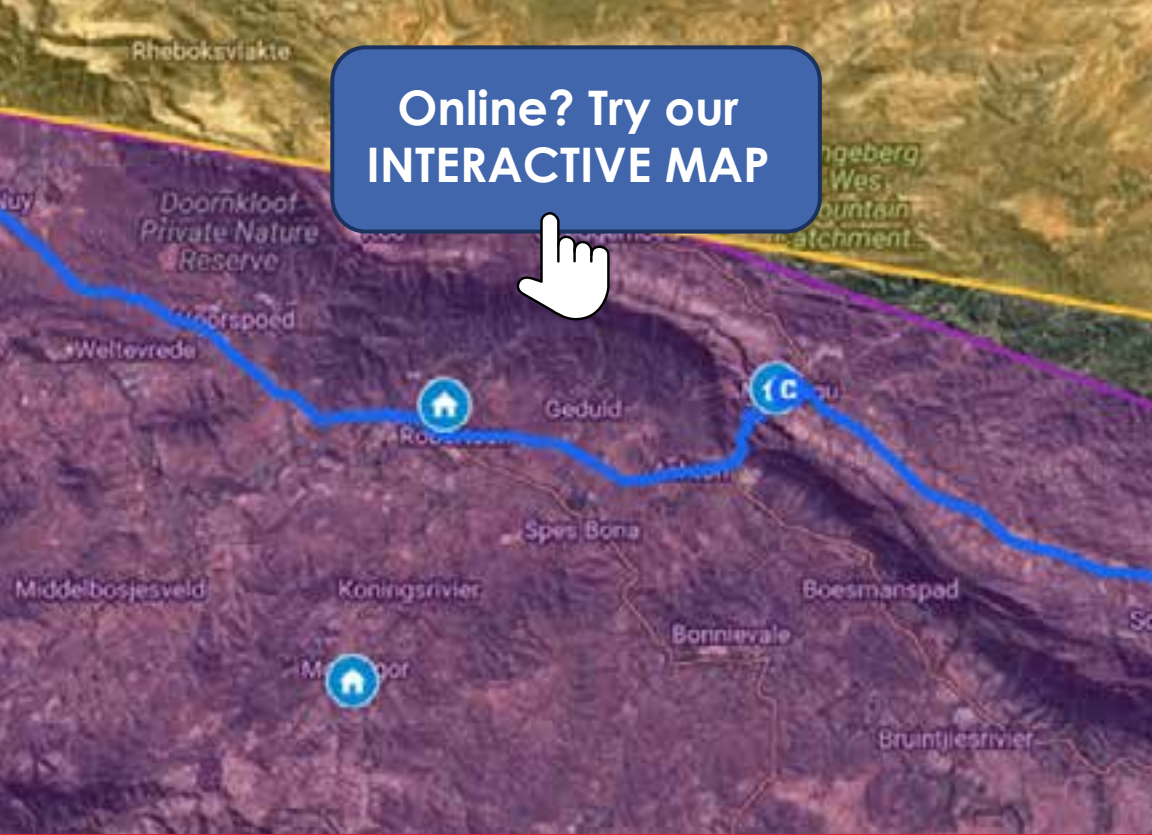
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BACKPACKING ROUTE 62

Route 62 is a premier inland alternative to the N2 coastal highway, stretching roughly 850 kilometres from Worcester to Humansdorp. It traverses the semi-arid Klein Karoo, a landscape defined by ancient Cape Fold Mountains, unique succulent flora, and a series of dramatic mountain passes.

The Journey and Landscape

The Route: The road connects fertile wine valleys and fruit orchards (Montagu and Langkloof) with the scrubland of the Klein Karoo. Key stops include Montagu, Barrydale, Ladismith, Calitzdorp, and the regional hub of Oudtshoorn.

Geology and Flora: Travelers pass through 330-million-year-old rock formations. The region is a biodiversity

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hotspot, home to over 500 species of succulents and the endangered blue crane.

The Swartberg Pass: A “non-negotiable” highlight, this 27-kilometre gravel road was engineered in the 1880s using dry-stone techniques. It remains one of Africa’s most celebrated mountain passes.

Practical Information for Backpackers

Transport: A hire car is essential, as there are no hop-on-hop-off services or reliable intercity links. While the roads are generally excellent, fuel should be topped up in main towns.

Timing: Spring (August–October) is the best time for wildflowers and golden afternoon light. Autumn (March–May) offers harvest colours and quieter roads. Summer can be intensely hot (35–40°C), while winter nights are very cold but the air is exceptionally clear.

Costs: Route 62 is highly affordable. A daily budget of €35–€55 covers dorm beds (€8–€15), meals (€6–€12), and affordable activities like visiting the Cango Caves or ostrich farms.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Route 62](#)

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ROUTE 62 HOSTELS

WORCESTER

- [TOLBOS BACKPACKERS](#)

ROBERTSON

- [ROBERTSON BOUTIQUE BACKPACKERS](#)

MONTAGU

- [DE BOS BACKPACKERS & CAMPING](#)

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: ROUTE 62

Town: WORCESTER

TOLBOS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 3 Bird Alley (off Bird Street), Worcester Central, Worcester, 6849

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.64017,19.44729](#)

PHONE: [+27 23 347 7148](#) / [+27 72 887 7007](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 887 7007](#)

EMAIL: hector@tolbosbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: tolbosbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.2 / 10 "Pleasant" (though recent scores fluctuate significantly)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Transit Hostel (Mixed Dorms, Private Dorms, and En-suite Family Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Very Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R650 (~\$35).

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ROBERTSON BOUTIQUE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 4 Dordrecht Ave, Robertson, 6705

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.79713,19.89119](#)

PHONE: [+27 23 626 1280](#) / [+27 72 447 5991](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 447 5991](#)

EMAIL: info@robertsonbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: robertsonbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 "Fabulous"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Country Backpackers (Mixed Dorms, Victorian Private Rooms, and Modern En-suite Garden Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R300 (~\$16); Private rooms from R650 (~\$35); En-suite Garden rooms from R900 (~\$48).



DE BOS BACKPACKERS & CAMPING

STREET ADDRESS: 8 Brown St, Montagu, 6720

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.78846,20.11336](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 462 8812](#) / [+27 23 614 2532](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 462 8812](#)

EMAIL: info@debos.co.za

WEBSITE: debos.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.9 / 10 "Excellent"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Adventure Farm & Backpackers (Dorms, Private Courtyard Rooms, Self-Catering Cottages, and Shaded Campsites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$14); Private rooms from R650 (~\$35); Camping from R150 (~\$8) per person.

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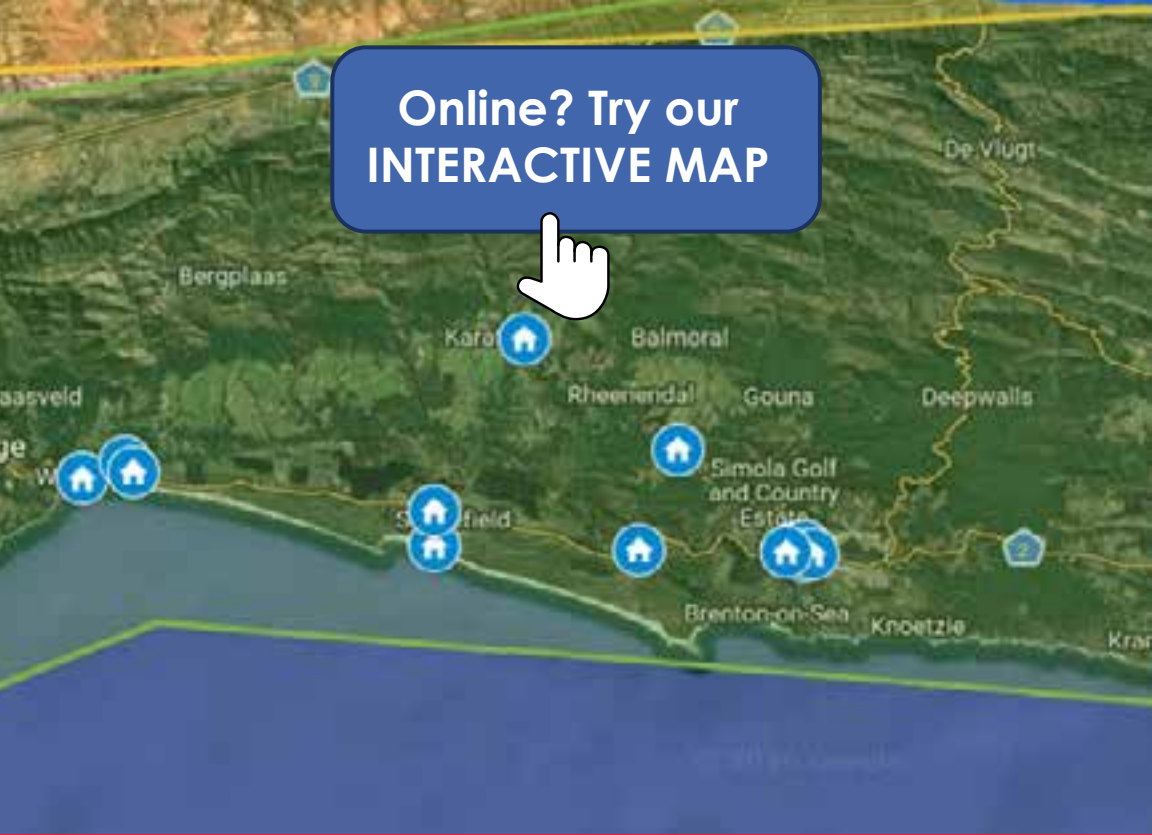
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BACKPACKING THE GARDEN ROUTE

The Garden Route is a 300-kilometre coastal corridor in South Africa, stretching from Mossel Bay to Storms River. While often marketed as a scenic “postcard” destination, it is actually an ecologically dense region featuring diverse floral kingdoms, ancient forests, and a complex human history.

History and People

The Khoisan Legacy: Long before European arrival, the area was home to the San (hunter-gatherers) and the Outeniqua (Khoikhoi honey-gatherers). Their presence survives in rock art and place-names like Outeniqua and Gamtoos. Today, a growing movement seeks political recognition and land restitution for Khoisan descendants.

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The Woodcutters: In the late 18th century, the Dutch established timber posts to harvest hardwoods like Yellowwood and Stinkwood. This era of intensive logging decimated the original forests and gave rise to a unique “woodcutter” culture, immortalized in Dalene Matthee’s literature.

Ecological Significance

Fynbos and Forest: The region sits within the Cape Floristic Region, home to 9,000 plant species (more endemics per sq. km than the Amazon). The landscape is a mosaic of fire-dependent fynbos and humid Afrotropical forests.

Wildlife: The Knysna Forest is home to “Strangefoot,” the last confirmed wild elephant of a once-massive herd.

The 2017 Fire: A catastrophic wildfire in 2017 destroyed over 800 buildings and 15,000 hectares. The disaster was exacerbated by a record drought and the accumulation of invasive alien plants, which remain a significant management challenge today.

Major Stops and Activities

Wilderness: A quiet hub of lakes and estuaries, ideal for birdwatching and kayaking.

Knysna: The commercial and social “jewel,” famous for its lagoon, sandstone Heads, and forest hiking trails.

Plettenberg Bay: Renowned for world-class beaches and the Robberg Nature Reserve.

Tsitsikamma: The wild eastern end, home to the Storms



River Mouth and the world-famous Otter Trail.

Practical Information for Backpackers

Transport: While intercity buses (including the Baz Bus) serve the N2, a hire car is strongly recommended to access forest trails, scenic passes, and hidden beaches.

Timing: October to April offers the best beach weather and wildflowers. May to September is ideal for whale watching and hiking the Otter Trail in cooler conditions.

Costs: Budget between €30–€90 per day depending on activities. Many of the best experiences—like cliff path walks and forest hikes—are free or very low-cost.

Safety: The Garden Route is relatively safe compared to major SA cities, but travellers should guard against car break-ins and be wary of natural hazards like powerful rip currents and fire risks.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Garden Route](#)

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GARDEN ROUTE HOSTELS

MOSSEL BAY

- [PARK HOUSE LODGE](#)
- [MILE CRUNCHERS BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SANTOS EXPRESS TRAIN LODGE](#)
- [SHARK SHACK BACKPACKERS](#)

GEORGE

- [GEORGE BACKPACKERS](#)

WILDERNESS

- [WILDERNESS BEACH HOUSE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [FAIRY KNOWE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [THE WILD FARM BACKPACKERS](#)

SEDFIELD

- [SEDFIELD BACKPACKER](#)
- [PILIPILI BEACH CABANAS](#)

KNYSNA

- [THE RIVERDECK LODGE AND BACKPACKERS](#)

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- [WILD SPIRIT BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)

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- [DIJEMBE BACKPACKERS](#)



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: MOSSEL BAY

PARK HOUSE LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 121 High St, Mossel Bay Central, Mossel Bay, 6506

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.18403,22.14056](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 691 1937](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@parkhouse.co.za

WEBSITE: parkhouse.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.0 / 10 "Wonderful"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Historic Guesthouse & Backpackers (Dormitories, family rooms, and en-suite doubles).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds typically from R250 (~\$13); Private rooms from R650 (~\$35) to R1,400 (~\$75) depending on season and unit size.



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: MOSSEL BAY

MILE CRUNCHERS BACKPACKERS & HOSTELLING

STREET ADDRESS: 7 Church St, CBD, Mossel Bay, 6500

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.18072,22.14312](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 690 4462](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: milecrushers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: milecrunchers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.7 / 10 "Pleasant"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget City Backpackers (Dormitories, private rooms, and a unique "indoor camping" area).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds typically from R150 (~\$8); Private rooms from R450 (~\$24) to R800 (~\$43).

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SANTOS EXPRESS TRAIN LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Munro Rd, Santos Beach, Mossel Bay, 6500

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.17816,22.1371](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 691 1995](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 943 0041](#)

EMAIL: reservations@santosexpress.co.za

WEBSITE: santosexpress.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.7 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Unique Train Hostel (Shared Coach Dorms, Twin Cabins, and Luxury Wood-Paneled Suites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R230 (~\$12); Twin cabins from R550 (~\$29); Royal Suites from R1,300 (~\$70).



SHARK SHACK BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 15 Marsh Street, Mossel Bay Central,
Mossel Bay, 6500

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.18281,22.15216](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 690 3109](#) / [+27 72 623 8275](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 493 3251](#)

EMAIL: sharkshack@gmail.com

WEBSITE: sharkshack.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.0 / 10 "Pleasant"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Adventure Hostel
(Mixed/Female Dorms and "En-suite" Private Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Very Budget. Dorm beds from R250
(~\$13); Private rooms from R600 (~\$32).

HOSTEL LIST



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GEORGE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 5 St John's St, Dormehls Drift, George, 6529

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.9596, 22.4536](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 873 0061](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@georgebackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: georgebackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.1 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Transit Hostel (Mixed Dorms and Private Twin/Double Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13); Private rooms from R550 (~\$29).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: WILDERNESS

WILDERNESS BEACH HOUSE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Western Road, Wilderness, 6560

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.99528,22.56594](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 495 1814](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 495 1814](#)

EMAIL: info@wildernessbeachhouse.com

WEBSITE: wildernessbeachhouse.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.6 / 10 "Fabulous"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Beachfront Adventure Hostel (Mixed/Female Dorms, En-suite Privates, and Family Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R280 (~\$15); Private rooms from R850 (~\$45).

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THE WILD FARM BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 291 Whites Road, Hoekwil, Wilderness, 6560

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.98661,22.59517](#)

PHONE: [+27 67 416 6773](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 67 416 6773](#)

EMAIL: info@wildfarmbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: wildfarmbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-friendly Backpacker Hostel & Campsite (Dorms, Log Cabins, and Private Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R250 (~\$13); Private rooms from R600 (~\$32) to R1,350 (~\$73).



FAIRY KNOWE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Dumbleton Rd, Wilderness, 6560

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.99263,22.59997](#)

PHONE: [+27 81 355 0137](#) / [+27 44 877 1285](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 443 8384](#)

EMAIL: info@wildernessbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: wildernessbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.9 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Adventure & Nature Backpackers (Mixed dorms, Double En-suites, Tents, and Campsites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13); Private en-suites from R750 (~\$40); Camping from R150 (~\$8).



SEDGEFIELD BACKPACKER

STREET ADDRESS: Main Service Road, Sedgefield, 6573

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.01362,22.80181](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 086 8174](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 086 8174](#)

EMAIL: sedgefieldbackpacker@gmail.com

WEBSITE: sedgefieldbackpacker.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Heritage Cottage Hostel
(Dorms, Private Double Rooms, and Themed Tents).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R250 (~\$13); Private rooms and Tents from R500 (~\$27).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: SEDGEFIELD

PILIPILI BEACH CABANAS

STREET ADDRESS: 2 Claude Urban Drive, Myoli Beach, Sedgefield, 6573

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03354,22.80204](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 343 3087](#) / [+27 44 343 1900](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 287 2475](#)

EMAIL: reservations@pilipili.co.za

WEBSITE: pilipili.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Beachfront Adventure Hub & Cabanas (Mixed Dorms, En-suite Family Rooms, and Honeymoon Suites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R465 (~\$25); Private Cabanas from R1,080 (~\$58).

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THE RIVERDECK LODGE AND BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: N2 National, Knysna, 6570

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03513,22.93926](#)

PHONE: [+27 78 134 5873](#) / [+27 44 333 0221](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 78 134 5873](#)

EMAIL: info@riverdeck.co.za

WEBSITE: riverdeckrestaurant.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.3 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Riverside Adventure Lodge (Wooden Cabins, Mixed Dorms, and Private En-suites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13); Private cabins from R850 (~\$45).



ISLAND VIBE BACKPACKERS KNYSNA

STREET ADDRESS: 67 Main Rd, Knysna Central, Knysna, 6571

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03608,23.04186](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 382 1728](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 612 5057](#)

EMAIL: knysna@islandvibe.co.za

WEBSITE: islandvibe.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.8 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Central Adventure Hostel (Dorms, Private En-suites, and "Flashpacker" Double Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R250 (~\$13); Private Rooms from R690 (~\$37).

HOSTEL LIST



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KNYSNA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 42 Queen Street, Knysna Central, Knysna, 6571, Western Cape, South Africa.

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03327,23.05116](#)

PHONE: [+27 60 498 0485](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 60 498 0485](#)

EMAIL: info@knysnabackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: knysnabackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, Private Double/Twin Rooms, and Family En-suite Rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R250, Private Rooms from R495, Family En-suite from R795.



KEEDOLS INN & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 4 Queen St, Knysna Central, Knysna, 6571

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03949,23.05022](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 923 9223](#) / [+27 44 382 2658](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 923 9223](#)

EMAIL: keedols@live.co.za

WEBSITE: keedols.co.za (Redirects often to booking portals)

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Personal Boutique Lodge & Backpackers (Mixed Dorms, En-suite Double/Twin Rooms, and an 18-sleeper Group Unit).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13); Private en-suites from R800 (~\$43); Large group units from R6,000 (~\$325).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: PLETTENBERG BAY

AMAKAYA BACKPACKERS & APARTMENTS

STREET ADDRESS: 15 Park Ln, Plettenberg Bay, 6600

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.05522,23.36861](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 533 4010](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 691 5756](#)

EMAIL: bookings@amakaya.co.za

WEBSITE: amakaya.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Central Flashpacker & Apartments (Mixed Dorms, Twin/Double En-suites, and Self-catering Apartments).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorms from R300 (~\$16); Private En-suites from R600 (~\$32) to R1,200 (~\$65).

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PLETT BEACHFRONT ACCOMMODATION

STREET ADDRESS: 22 Hopwood St, Plettenberg Bay, 6600

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.05975,23.37668](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 533 4688](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 458 5344](#)

EMAIL: info@plettbeachfront.co.za

WEBSITE: plettbeachfrontaccommodation.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Beachfront Adventure Hostel
(Mixed/Female Dorms and Private En-suite Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R320 (~\$17); Private en-suites from R850 (~\$45).



BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: WESTERN CAPE

Region: GARDEN ROUTE

Town: PLETTENBERG BAY

PLETT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 21 Main St, Plettenberg Bay, 6600

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.05419,23.37264](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 339 9531](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 339 9531](#)

EMAIL: info@pletbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: pletbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Central Penthouse Hostel (En-suite Dorms and Private Penthouse Suites).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R250 (~\$13); Private Rooms from R650 (~\$35).

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BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: GARDEN ROUTE

City/Town: PLETTENBERG BAY

NOTHANDO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 5 Wilder St, Plettenberg Bay, 6600

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.05504,23.36977](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 533 0220](#) / [+27 82 825 9811](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 825 9811](#)

EMAIL: info@nothando.co.za

WEBSITE: nothando.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.6 / 10 "Fabulous"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Upscale "Flashpacker" Lodge
(Dorms and Private En-suite Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorms from R280 (~\$15); Private En-suites from R800 (~\$43).

HOSTEL LIST

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: GARDEN ROUTE

City/Town: PLETTENBERG BAY/THE CRAGS

WILD SPIRIT BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Khoisanania Farm, R102 Nature's Valley Road, The Craggs, 6602

FIND ON GOOGLE MAPS: [33.9486.23.52112](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 828 8008](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 828 8008](#)

EMAIL: book.wildspirit@gmail.com

WEBSITE: wildspiritlodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Bunk-free Dorms, Safari Tents, and Forest Camping.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms from R210 (~\$12); Camping from R120 (~\$7).

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TUBE 'N AXE BUDGET ACCOMMODATION

STREET ADDRESS: 85 Darnell St, Storms River, Stormsriver, 6308

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.9728,23.88294](#)

PHONE: [+27 42 281 1757](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 153 0151](#)

EMAIL: info@tubenaxe.co.za

WEBSITE: tubenaxe.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Hybrid Adventure Lodge (Dorms, Tented Units, and Boutique Private Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorms from R260 (~\$14); Safari Tents from R450 (~\$24); Boutique Private Rooms from R1,100 (~\$60).



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: GARDEN ROUTE

City/Town: STORMS RIVER

DIJEMBE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 59 Formosa St, Stormsriver, 6308

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.96997,23.88176](#)

PHONE: [+27 79 342 2036](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 342 2036](#)

EMAIL: dijembe@gmail.com

WEBSITE: dijembebackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Rustic Adventure Hostel
(Mixed/Female Dorms, Private Log Cabins, and Safari
Tents).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm beds from R240 (~\$13); Private cabins from R750 (~\$40).



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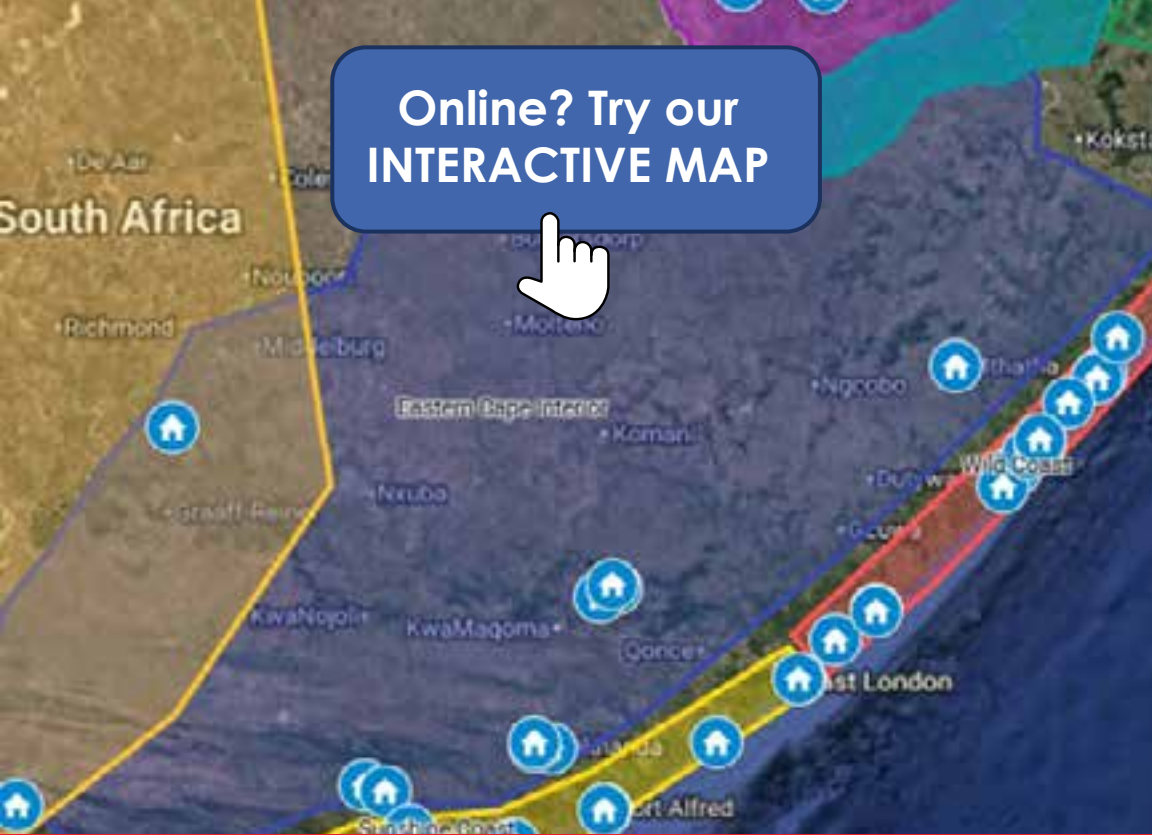
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THE EASTERN CAPE INTERIOR

The Eastern Cape Interior offers a quieter, more enigmatic alternative to South Africa's coastal routes. Stretching across roughly 600km, this circuit encompasses ancient indigenous forests, world-class wildlife reserves, and remote artist colonies. It is the heartland of the Xhosa culture and provides an unhurried experience away from traditional tourist crowds.

Key Destinations

Addo Elephant National Park: Originally a rescue mission for 11 surviving elephants, the park now hosts over 700. It is a malaria-free "Big Seven" reserve, incorporating the traditional Big Five plus the great white shark and southern right whale in its offshore sections.

Hogsback: Nestled in the Amathole Mountains, this vil-

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lage is famed for its mist-wreathed yellowwood forests and waterfalls. Local legend is that it inspired J.R.R. Tolkien's Middle-earth.

Nieu-Bethesda: A remote Karoo village known for the Owl House, the former home of artist Helen Martins. Her obsessive vision—expressed through ground-glass walls and hundreds of cement sculptures—has made the town a National Monument.

Makhanda (Grahamstown): A historic university town that hosts the National Arts Festival every July, the third-largest arts festival in the world.

Practical Information for Backpackers

Transport: A hire car is essential, as public transport is virtually non-existent between these specific stops. Roads are generally good, but the final 27km into Nieu-Bethesda is gravel.

Timing: Winter (May–August) is best for wildlife viewing at Addo. July is the peak for Makhanda due to the Arts Festival. Summer (October–February) is ideal for the lush forests of Hogsback, though winter offers a cosy, occasionally snowy atmosphere.

Budget: This is one of the most affordable regions in South Africa. Dorm beds cost approximately €5–€10, and a daily budget of €20–€40 covers most meals and activities.

Safety: The region is low-risk, though Makhanda requires standard urban vigilance against petty theft. In nature, visitors should respect wildlife in Addo and prepare for rapid weather changes in the mountains of Hogsback.

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EASTERN CAPE INTERIOR HOSTELS

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MAKHANDA

- [BLUE SKIES BACKPACKERS](#)
- [THE SMOKEY MOON](#)

HOGSBACK

- [ELUNDINI BACKPACKERS](#)
- [AWAY WITH THE FAIRIES BACKPACKERS](#)
- [TERRA KHAYA ECO BACKPACKERS](#)



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: ADDO

ORANGE ELEPHANT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: R335 Main Road, Addo, 6105, Eastern Cape, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.51418,25.69329](#)

PHONE: [+27 42 233 0023](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 74 179 6715](#)

EMAIL: info@addobackpackers.com

WEBSITE: addobackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.6 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dorms (Mixed), Private Double/Twin Rooms (En-suite or Shared), Tents, Family Cottages.

PRICE RANGE: R300 – R1,200 per night (Budget-friendly)

VIBE-METER: Social, rustic, and farm-focused with a legendary pub atmosphere

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: MAKHANDA

BLUE SKIES BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Cradock Road (R350), Makhandia (Grahamstown), 6140, Eastern Cape, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.5869,28.75954](#)

PHONE: [+27 84 278 3193](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 278 3193](#)

EMAIL: blueskiesbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.7 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed dormitories, Twin rooms, Double rooms (some en-suite), Large family rooms (sleeping up to 7).

PRICE RANGE: R200 – R850 per night.



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: MAKHANDA

THE SMOKEY MOON

STREET ADDRESS: Three Chimneys Farm Worcester Street Extension, Grahamstown, Makhandá, 6139

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.57472,23.71639](#)

PHONE: [+27 81 531 5448](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 81 531 5448](#)

EMAIL: jaybdd@gmail.com

WEBSITE: cannastay.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dormitories, Private Rooms, Camping, and Eco-Cottages.

PRICE RANGE: R180 (Camping) – R580 (Private Rooms) per night.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: ASHTON

ELUNDINI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Elundini Village, Lushington, Hogsback Area, 5721, Eastern Cape.

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.6352, 26.8558](#)

PHONE: [+27 78 357 3285](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 78 357 3285](#)

EMAIL: info@elundinibackpackers.com

WEBSITE: elundinibackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.2 / 10 "Superb"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Friendly Cultural Hostel
Shared Dormitory (Traditional Rondavel) Private Double/Twin Rondavels Family Rondavels (up to 4 sleepers)
Camping Facilities Note: Completely off-grid; no electricity in rooms (charging available in main hub).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping from R100 (~\$5) per night. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13). Private rooms from R600 (~\$32).

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: HOGSBACK

AWAY WITH THE FAIRIES BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 24 Hydrangea Lane Hogsback 5721
Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.5956, 26.9248](#)

PHONE: [+27 45 962 1031](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 668 0602](#)

EMAIL: hogsback1@gmail.com

WEBSITE: awaywiththefairies.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Nature Lodge & Backpackers
Shared Mixed Dormitories Private En-suite Rooms Self-Catering
Hobbit Cottages Camping Sites Note: Features the world-famous cliff-edge outdoor bathtub.
PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping from R130 (~\$7) per night. Dorm beds from R250 (~\$13). Private rooms from R750 (~\$40).

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: E. CAPE INTERIOR

City/Town: HOGSBACK

TERRA KHAYA ECO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Chillington Farm, Hogsback, 5721, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.6074, 26.9423](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 897 7503](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 897 7503](#)

EMAIL: info@terrakhaya.co.za

WEBSITE: terrakhaya.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Off-Grid Eco-Lodge & Permaculture Farm. Mixed Dormitories (Wattle & Daub Rondavels). Private Eco-Cabins (built from recycled materials). Secluded Self-Catering Units. Meadow Camping.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping from R140 (~US\$9) per night; Dorm beds from R250 (~US\$16); Private rooms from R620 (~US\$40). Note: Prices increase during peak "Horsing Around" event weeks.

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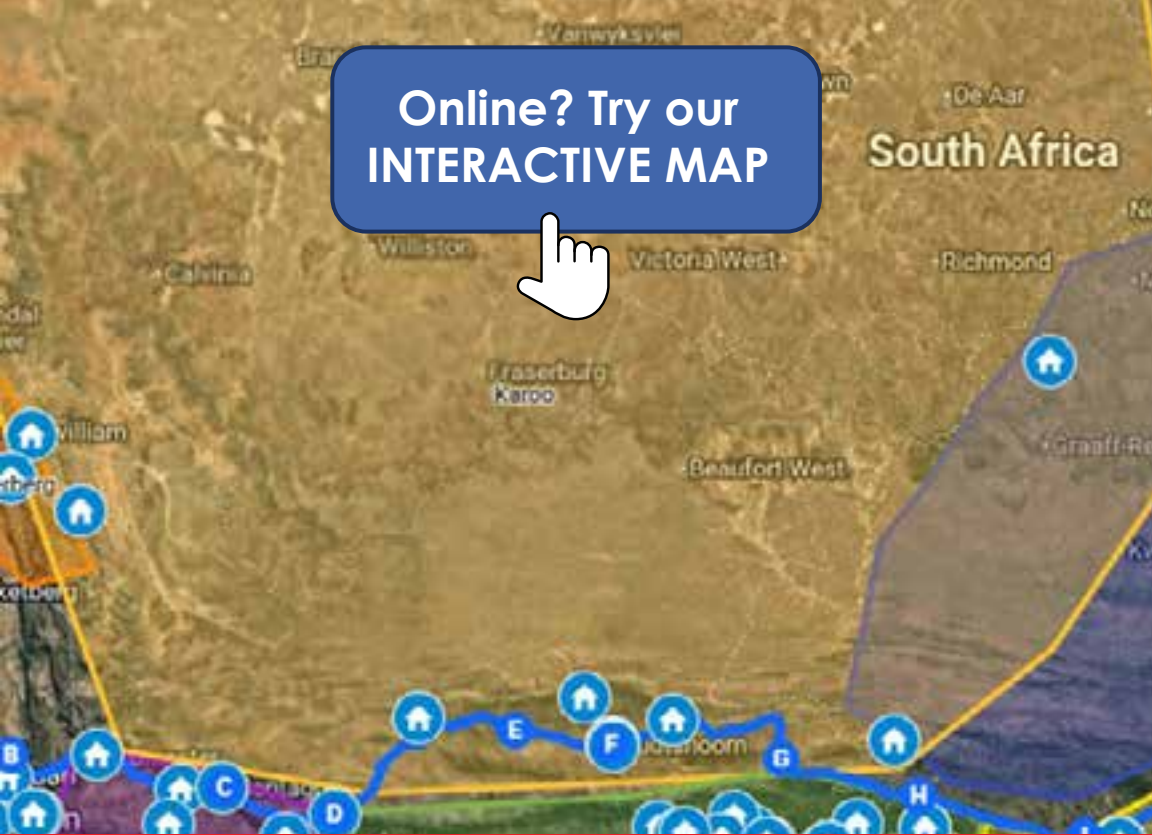
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THE KAROO & NORTHERN CAPE

Combining the vast, arid heartland of the Karoo with the immense, star-drenched wilderness of the Northern Cape, this guide covers South Africa's most soul-stirring interior. From ancient San rock art to the world's deepest man-made crater, this is a landscape defined by silence, scale, and extreme beauty.

The Karoo: A Land of Two Parts

The Karoo is where South Africa stops performing and starts being itself. It is a semi-arid plateau that records 250 million years of evolution in its rocks.

The Great Karoo: The vast, desolate northern plateau. Highlights include the artistic village of Nieu-Bethesda (home to the glass-encrusted Owl House) and the historic "dorpies" of Prince Albert and Graaff-Reinet.

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The Little Karoo (Klein Karoo): A more compact, greener valley following Route 62. Oudtshoorn is the hub, famous for the subterranean wonders of the Cango Caves and its ostrich farming history.

Baviaanskloof: A 200km World Heritage wilderness valley. It is a remote 4x4 territory offering the legendary Leopard Trail hike.

The Northern Cape: South Africa's Final Frontier
The largest and most sparsely populated province, the Northern Cape is a place of extremes—from the red dunes of the Kalahari to the floral explosions of Namaqualand.

The San (First People): The world's oldest continuous culture. To engage ethically, visit !Xaus Lodge (community-owned) or the Wildebeest Kuil Rock Art Centre to see ancient engravings through the eyes of San guides.

Kimberley & The Big Hole: Born from a 19th-century diamond rush, this massive crater is the largest hand-dug hole on Earth. While a marvel of engineering, it also stands as a sobering monument to the racialised labour system that followed.

The Natural Wonders:

Namaqualand: Between August and October, the desert transforms into a literal carpet of millions of wildflowers.

Kgalagadi Transfrontier Park: Home to the iconic black-maned Kalahari lion and vast red dunes.

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The Richtersveld: A mountain desert of “halfmens” succulents and “quiver trees” (kokerbooms) that looks like the surface of another planet.

Sutherland: Home to the SALT telescope, this high-altitude town offers some of the clearest, darkest stargazing on the planet.

Backpacker Essentials

Transport: A car is essential. Distances are enormous (e.g., 400km between major towns), and public transport is virtually non-existent. Always keep your fuel tank topped up and carry spare water.

Timing: Spring (Aug–Oct) is best for flowers and hiking. Winter (Jun–Aug) is freezing at night but perfect for stargazing and wildlife viewing. Summer is brutally hot, often exceeding 45°C.

Safety: Exceptionally safe regarding crime, but environmentally dangerous. Heatstroke and remote breakdowns are the primary risks.

Crossing to Namibia: The Vioolsdrif (N7) crossing is the standard route, but the hand-cranked Sendelingsdrift pontoon through the Richtersveld is the ultimate adventure entry point.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Karoo](#) and [backpacking Northern Cape](#)



KAROO & NORTHERN CAPE HOSTELS

BAVIAANSKLOOF & GREAT KAROO

- [GO BAVIAANS \(CEDAR FALLS BASE CAMP\)](#)
- [OWLHOUSE BACKPACKERS](#)

LITTLE KAROO

- [LODGE 96](#)
- [SWARTBERG BACKPACKERS](#)
- [OASIS SHANTI BACKPACKERS](#)
- [KAROO SOUL BACKPACKERS](#)

NORTHERN CAPE

KALAHARI

- [AUGRABIES BACKPACKERS](#)

KIMBERLEY

- [GUM TREE LODGE](#)

RICHTERSVELD

- [THE GROWCERY CAMP](#)



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: GREAT KAROO

City/Town: BAVIAANSKLOOF

GO BAVIAANS (CEDAR FALLS BASE CAMP)

STREET ADDRESS: Cedar Falls Farm, Baviaanskloof, Willowmore, 6445, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.57472,23.71639](#)

PHONE: [+27 74 939 4395](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 74 939 4395](#)

EMAIL: reservations@gobaviaans.co.za

WEBSITE: gobaviaans.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mountain Wilderness Base Camp. Backpackers (3 rooms sleeping 4 each). Historic Farmhouses (Cedar Farmhouse, Red Cliffs Farmhouse). Romantic Cottages (Cob Cottage, Heuningboshuisie). Multi-day Trail Huts (Leopard Trail).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range/Budget. Backpackers from R600 (~US\$39) per room (bring own bedding). Romantic Cottages from R980 (~US\$64). Large Farmhouses from R3200 (US\$209) per night for the unit.

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: LITTLE KAROO

City/Town: OUDTSHOORN

LODGE 96

STREET ADDRESS: 9696 Langenhoven Road, Oudtshoorn, 6620, Western Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.6036,22.20924](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 272 2996](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 492 5815](#)

EMAIL: lodge96@telkomsa.net

WEBSITE: lodge96.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.4 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed-use Lodge. Backpackers (8-bed mixed dorm). Private Double Rooms (En-suite or Shared Bath). Deluxe Family Room.

PRICE RANGE: Budget-Friendly. Dorm beds from R300 (~US\$20). Private doubles with shared bath from R550 (~US\$36). En-suite family rooms up to R1300 (~US\$85).

HOSTEL LIST

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: LITTLE KAROO

City/Town: OUDTSHOORN

OASIS SHANTI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 3 Church Street, Oudtshoorn, 6625,
Western Cape, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.5899, 22.2107](#)

PHONE: [+27 44 279 1163](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: oasis@mailbox.co.za

WEBSITE: oasisshanti.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

SOLO-FEMALE-FRIENDLINESS SCORECARD: 4 / 5. The management (frequently praised in reviews for being communicative and helpful) creates a safe, welcoming environment. The property is well-gated and secure.

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KAROO SOUL BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 170 Langenhoven Road (Front) or 1 Adlerley Street (Back Entrance), Oudtshoorn, 6625

PHONE: [+27 44 272 0330](tel:+27442720330)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 781 7361](tel:+27827817361)

EMAIL: info@karoosoul.com

WEBSITE: karoosoul.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.1 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed Dormitories, Private En-suite Rooms, Family Units, Stone Cottages, and limited Camping.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorms from ~R250–R350; Private rooms from ~R680 (singles) to ~R800 (doubles); Family units/Cottages up to ~R1,400

SOLO-FEMALE-FRIENDLINESS SCORECARD: 4.5 / 5. The property is managed by a very hands-on and welcoming hostess (Ilze); the area is suburban and generally safe, and the "uncrowded" nature of the dorms adds a level of comfort.



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: LITTLE KAROO

City/Town: MATJIESRIVIER

SWARTBERG BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Farm Voorbedacht, Matjiesrivier District, Oudtshoorn, 6620, Western Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.38218,22.05788](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 896 3082](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 896 3082](#)

EMAIL: info@swartbergbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: swartbergbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Farm-based Backpackers & Self-Catering. Two 8-bed dormitories, private en-suite double rooms, and self-catering units with private hot tubs.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm beds from R250 (~US\$16). Private double rooms with en-suite from R700 (~US\$46). Self-catering units with hot tubs from R1000 (~US\$66).

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: GREAT KAROO

City/Town: NIEU-BETHESDA

OWLHOUSE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Martins Street, Nieu-Bethesda, 6286, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.8676,24.55422](#)

PHONE: [+27 49 841 1642](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 742 7113](#)

EMAIL: backpackers@owlhouse.info

WEBSITE: owlhouse.info

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 "Very Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Bohemian Eco-Hostel. Offers Mixed Dormitories, Twin/Private Rooms (shared ablutions), and garden camping sites.

PRICE RANGE: Budget-Friendly. Dorm beds from R250. Private rooms from R750. Camping from R150 per person.

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Province: NORTHERN CAPE

Area: RICHTERSVELD

City/Town: VIOOLSDRIFT

THE GROWCERY CAMP

STREET ADDRESS: Plot 215, Vioolsdrift, 8240, Northern Cape (Approx. 22km from the Vioolsdrift Border Post)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.6968,17.49771](#)

PHONE: [+27 27 761 8007](#) / [+27 84 604 2756](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 604 2756](#)

EMAIL: info@thegrowcery.co.za / book.growcery@gmail.com

WEBSITE: thegrowcery.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-conscious Bush Camp. Offers "Chic Shacks" (upcycled cabins), grassed camp-sites, and permanent tented camps.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range; Camping: Approx. R220 – R280 per person; Chic Shacks: Approx. R380 – R410 (Room only / B&B).

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Province: NORTHERN CAPE

Area: KALAHARI

City/Town: AUGRABIES

AUGRABIES BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Rooipad Farm, Augrabies, 8240, Northern Cape (Approx. 10km from the National Park entrance)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.66169,20.4124](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 515 6079](#) / [+27 82 255 1860](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 515 6079](#)

EMAIL: augrabiesfallsbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: augrabies.iblog.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Working Farm & Backpacker Lodge. Offers private en-suite rooms, budget "standard" rooms, and a fenced-off campsite for tents and overlanders.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: Approx. R150 – R200 per person; Dorm/Sharing: Approx. R240 – R300; Private Units: R850 – R950 (Unit price).

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Province: NORTHERN CAPE

Area: GREAT KAROO

City/Town: KIMBERLEY

GUM TREE LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: R64 Old Bloemfontein Road, Hull Street, Kimberley, 8301, Northern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.73798,24.80766](#)

PHONE: [+27 53 832 8577](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: gumtreelodge@telkomsa.net

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 5.0 / 10 ("Bad" based on recent volume, though historically a budget staple)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Large-scale Budget Lodge & Backpackers. Capacity for up to 200 guests. Offers everything from 40-bed dorms and 6-bed dorms to private en-suite rooms and self-catering family units.

PRICE RANGE: Very Budget. Dorms from R120. Private rooms from R250.

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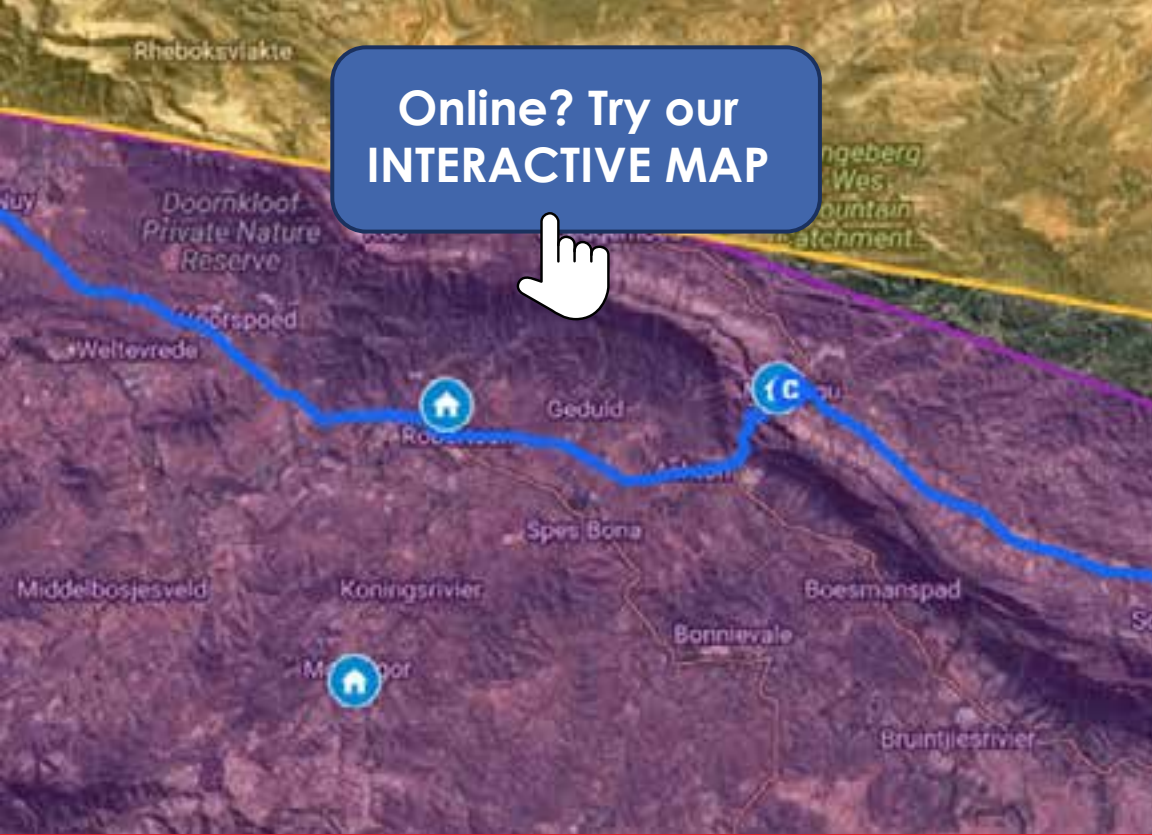
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CAPE WEST COAST & CEDERBERG

This guide combines the windswept beauty of the Atlantic West Coast with the ancient sandstone wilderness of the adjacent Cederberg. While the Garden Route gets the crowds, these regions offer a raw, “anti-resort” experience defined by silence, scale, and extreme natural beauty.

The West Coast: Salt, Surf and Flowers

The West Coast is a landscape “scraped clean” by the Atlantic’s Benguela Current and the Cape Doctor wind. It is a region of whitewashed fishing villages and vast, empty horizons.

The Flower Phenomenon: In August and September, the semi-arid landscape “detonates” into a horizon-to-hori-

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zon carpet of wildflowers. The Postberg section of West Coast National Park is the epicentre, opening only during these two months.

Langebaan Lagoon: A turquoise, Mediterranean-style lagoon that is a global mecca for kite surfing from November to March. It offers a warmer, sheltered alternative to the freezing open Atlantic.

Seafood and Surf: Visit Paternoster for its iconic white cottages or Langebaan for a 10-course seafood feast at Die Strandloper. For surfers, Elands Bay offers a world-class left-hand point break that draws serious riders into its quiet, cold waters.

The Cederberg: Ancient Rock and Silence

Two hours inland, the landscape shifts abruptly to orange sandstone mountains. The Cederberg is a premier destination for hiking and bouldering, and one of South Africa's oldest inhabited regions.

San Rock Art: The mountains hold one of the world's densest concentrations of ancient San paintings, some over 6,000 years old. Sites like the Stadsaal Caves are easily accessible, while others require local community guides.

The Wilderness Area: Centred around the Algeria valley, this is a land of dramatic formations like the Wolfberg Arch and Maltese Cross. It is a place of absolute silence where the Milky Way is bright enough to cast a shadow.



Cultural Heritage: The Wupperthal Mission and outposts like Heuningvlei offer a glimpse into deep-rooted Moravian farming communities. Visiting here supports direct community development initiatives.

Backpacker Essentials

Transport: A car is non-negotiable. There is no public transport or Baz Bus service. Expect gravel roads; while sedans usually manage the main Algeria road, high-clearance vehicles are better for remote spots like Heuningvlei. Always fill your tank before entering the interior.

Timing: Spring (Aug–Oct) is the “Golden Window” for both regions—flowers on the coast and perfect hiking weather in the mountains. Summer is ideal for kite surfing but brings 40°C+ heat to the Cederberg.

Safety: Exceptionally safe from crime, but environmentally demanding. Risks include cold water shock in the 12°C Atlantic, dehydration on mountain trails, and flash floods in sandstone gorges.

Connectivity: The Cederberg is a “digital detox” by necessity; mobile signal is almost non-existent in the interior valleys. Download offline maps (Maps.me/Google) before you leave.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking West Coast](#)

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WEST COAST & CEDERBERG HOSTELS

WEST COAST

- [WINDSTONE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [JACOBS BAY BACKPACKERS \(THE PLOT\)](#)
- [WEST COAST BACKPACKERS \(COZY CORNER\)](#)
- [ELANDS BAY OFFSHORE SURF BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SEA SHACK](#)
- [THE SURF SHACK HOUSE & BACKPACKERS](#)

CEDERBERG

- [HEUNINGVLEI BACKPACKERS](#)

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WINDSTONE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: R45, Vredenburg, 7380, Western Cape
(10km from Vredenburg toward Hopefield)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.03065,18.28789](#)

PHONE: [+27 22 766 1645](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 290 7641](#)

EMAIL: andy@windstone.co.za

WEBSITE: windstone.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Guest Farm & Group Lodge.
Features a dedicated backpacker wing with en-suite rooms (6 people per room), a large dormitory wing for groups (up to 100+ people), and a grassy campsite for overlanders.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: Approx. R150 per person; Dorms: From R120 - R180 per person; Family/Private Units: From R650 - R1,150 per unit.



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: WEST COAST

City/Town: JACOBS BAY

JACOBS BAY BACKPACKERS (THE PLOT)

STREET ADDRESS: Plot 307, Main Road, Jacobs Bay, 7380, Western Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.96296,17.89411](#)

PHONE: [+27 22 715 3034](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 822 0047](#)

EMAIL: theplot@jacobsbay.co.za

WEBSITE: jacobsbayaccommodations.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.1 / 10 ("Pleasant")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Glamping & Backpackers. A diverse mix of A-frame bedded tents, a "Stone House," private en-suite rooms, dormitories, and traditional campsites.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Camping: From R150 per person; A-Frame Tents: From R450 per unit; Private Rooms/Stone House: R750 – R1,100 per unit.

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Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: WEST COAST

City/Town: LANGEBAAN

WEST COAST BACKPACKERS (COZY CORNER)

STREET ADDRESS: 88 Main Street, Langebaan, 7357, Western Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.80994,17.88733](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 880 3561](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 880 3561](#)

EMAIL: info@langebaanholidayhomes.com

WEBSITE: langebaanholidayhomes.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.0 / 10 ("Superb")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Backpacker Hostel & Kite-House. Offers a mix of mixed-gender dormitories, female-only dorms, and private double rooms with shared or en-suite facilities.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms: From R250 - R320 per person; Private Rooms: From R650 - R900 per room.

HOSTEL LIST

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ELANDS BAY OFFSHORE SURF BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: R366, Elands Bay, 8110 (located "at the point" near the hotel)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.3140.18.3441](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 252 4326](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 252 4326](#)

EMAIL: info@elandsbayhotel.co.za

WEBSITE: elandsbayhotel.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf-focused Backpackers. Includes "The Barracks" (dormitory style), basic private rooms, and a self-contained caravan unit.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms/Barracks: From R250 – R350 per person; Caravan/Private Units: From R450 – R650 per unit.



Province: WESTERN CAPE

Area: WEST COAST

City/Town: PATERNOSTER

SEA SHACK

STREET ADDRESS: Soldaten Bay, Cape Columbine Nature Reserve, Paternoster, 7381

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.81869,17.85535](#)

PHONE: [+27 79 820 6824](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 820 6824](#)

EMAIL: info@seashack.co.za

WEBSITE: seashack.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-friendly "Glamping" Backpackers. Includes 10 themed wooden shacks, permanent tents, and a family unit ("Spongebob").

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Budget. Shacks (Front Row/Garden): From R990 – R1,210 per unit (sleeps 2); Tents: From R650 – R790 per unit.

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THE SURF SHACK HOUSE & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 14 Strand St, Elands Bay, 8110, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.30908,18.3429](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 556 6012](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 541 2936](#)

EMAIL: info@elandsbayguesthouse.co.za

WEBSITE: elandsbayguesthouse.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com



GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf House & Backpackers.

Features a mix of shared dormitory "bunk" rooms, private annex units, and a larger self-catering main house.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Beds: From R300 – R400 per person; Annex Units: From R750 (Single) to R1,650 (4-5 persons); Main House: From R4,250 (Full house hire).

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HEUNINGVLEI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Heuningvlei Village (Outpost of Wupperthal), Cederberg, 8138

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.20195,19.09724](#)

PHONE: [+27 27 492 8001](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 820 6824](#)

(General Cederberg Heritage Route Inquiry)

EMAIL: mjdwesthuizen@telkomsa.net

WEBSITE: heuningvlei.yolasite.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Community-run Mountain Lodge. Features a 16-bed dormitory (converted school-house), private rooms, and a wilderness campsite.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm/Room: From R150 – R250 per person; Camping: From R80 – R120 per person.



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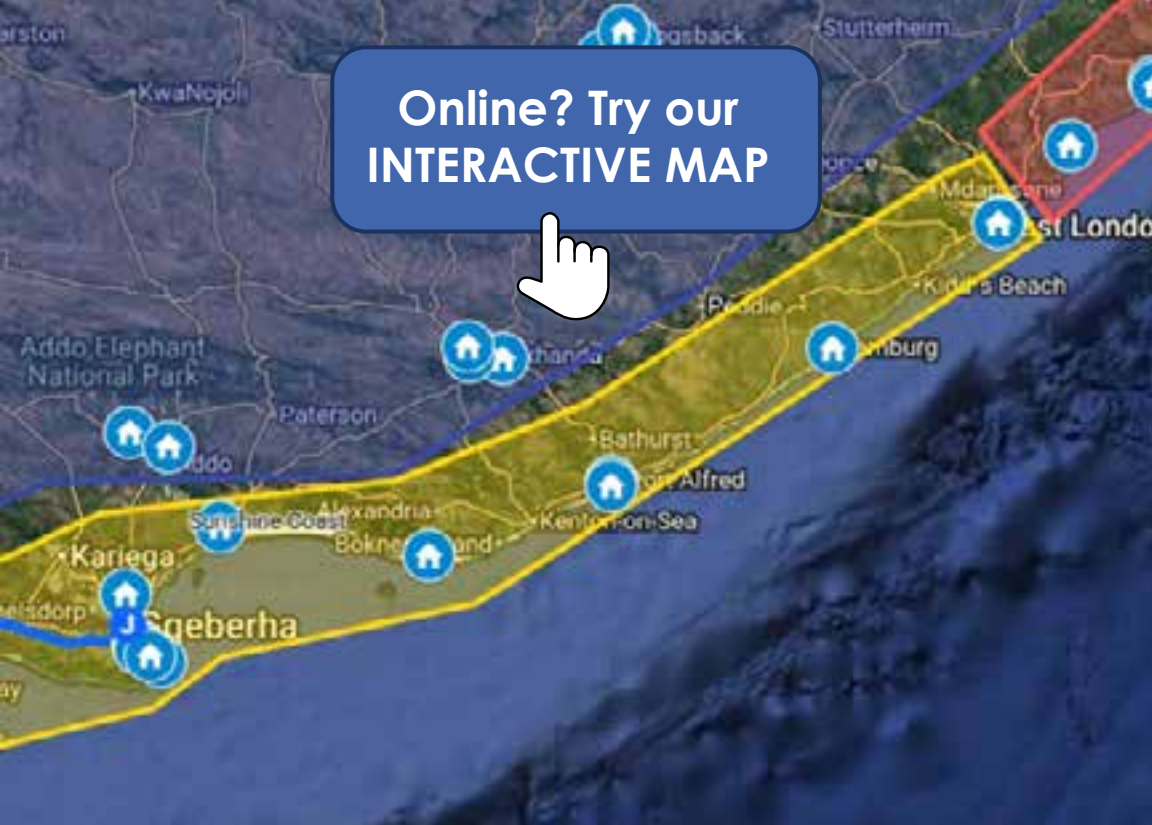
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BACKPACKING THE SUNSHINE COAST

The Sunshine Coast offers a wilder, more unpolished alternative to the Garden Route, stretching 500km between the Tsitsikamma forests and East London. True to its name, the region enjoys over 320 days of sunshine annually, making it a reliable year-round destination where the warm Indian Ocean remains swimmable even in winter.

The Layout: Surf, Rivers and Elephants

The region is a sequence of diverse landscapes, from the world-class right-hand point breaks of Jeffreys Bay to the vast dune fields and elephant herds of the Addo Elephant National Park.

The Hubs: Gqeberha (Port Elizabeth) and East London serve as the main urban gateways, while the R72 coastal

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road winds through charming river towns like Kenton-on-Sea and Port Alfred.

The Hinterland: Inland lies the academic city of Makhanda (Grahamstown) and “pineapple country,” featuring the historic village of Bathurst—home to South Africa’s oldest licensed pub.

The Water: With sea temperatures averaging 18–24°C, the coast is a haven for dolphins, whales, and surfers.

Backpacker Essentials

Transport: While the Baz Bus services Jeffreys Bay, Gqeberha, and East London via the N2, a hire car is essential to explore the scenic R72 coastal route and the inland game reserves.

Costs: This is one of South Africa’s most affordable stretches. Dorm beds range from £7–£14, and a comfortable daily budget of £35–£50 covers accommodation, food, and activities like surf lessons or self-drive safaris.

Timing: Winter (May–August) is prime surf season and brings dry, warm days. Summer (November–March) is hot and perfect for swimming, though school holiday crowds peak in December.

Safety: The small beach towns are very relaxed and safe. In the larger cities, standard urban protocols apply. Note that the ocean is a wild ecosystem; always heed local shark warnings, particularly in East London.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Sunshine Coast](#)

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SUNSHINE COAST HOSTELS

ST FRANCIS

- [SEALS BACKPACKERS](#)
- [ST FRANCIS BAY BACKPACKERS](#)

JEFFREYS BAY

- [ISLAND VIBE JEFFREYS BAY](#)
- [JEFFREYS BAY BACKPACKERS](#)
- [AFRICAN UBUNTU BACKPACKERS](#)
- [THE LITTLE HOUSE ON SUPERS AT SUPERTUBES](#)

GQEBERHA (PORT ELIZABETH)

- [IKHAYALAM LODGE](#)
- [LUNGILE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [IKHAYALAM LODGE](#)
- [LUNGILE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [JIKELEZA LODGE BACKPACKERS HOSTEL](#)
- [THE HIPPO BACKPACKERS](#)
- [RIVERFRONT BACKPACKERS](#)



SUNSHINE COAST HOSTELS *(Continued)*

GQEBERHA (PORT ELIZABETH)

- [WOODLANDS COTTAGES & BACKPACKERS](#)
- [WOODY CAPE BACKPACKERS](#)

PORT ALFRED

- [KOWIE BACKPACKERS](#)

HAMBURG

- [HAMBURG BACKPACKERS](#)

EAST LONDON

- [BUFFALO BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SUGAR SHACK BACKPACKERS](#)

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: CAPE ST FRANCIS

SEALS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 116 Da Gama Road, Cape St. Francis,
6312, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.19856,24.83189](#)

PHONE: [+27 76 962 5595](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 962 5595](#)

EMAIL: sealsbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: sealsbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf-centric Hostel & Lodge.

Offers mixed dormitories, private twin/double rooms,
and a self-contained family cottage.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Beds: From
R280 – R350 per person; Private Rooms: From R750 –
R1,100 per room.

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ST FRANCIS BAY BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 3 Assissi Drive, St Francis Bay, 6312, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.1652,24.82757](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 344 6451](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 344 6451](#)

EMAIL: stfrancisbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Upmarket Urban Backpackers. Features a mix of 10-bed mixed dorms, a 10-bed female-only dorm, and private double/twin en-suite rooms with balconies.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R250 – R320; Private Rooms: From R800 – R1,100.



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: JEFFREYS BAY

ISLAND VIBE JEFFREYS BAY

STREET ADDRESS: 10 Dageraad Street, Jeffreys Bay, 6330

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.06052,24.92491](#)

PHONE: [+27 42 293 1625](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 195 2445](#)

EMAIL: jbay@islandvibe.co.za

WEBSITE: islandvibe.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.9 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Festive Coastal Backpackers. Offers a tiered range including 12-bed and 8-bed dorms, budget private rooms, and the "Flashpacker" house with upscale en-suite rooms (some with jacuzzis).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Beds: From R180 – R250; Standard Privates: From R650 – R900; Flashpacker Suites: From R1,200 – R1,600.

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JEFFREYS BAY BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 12 Jeffrey Street, Jeffreys Bay, 6330

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.0517,24.92183](#)

PHONE: [+27 42 293 1379](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 42 293 1379](#)

EMAIL: jbaybackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: jbaybackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.3 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Central Urban Backpackers.

Offers a mix of 8-bed and 10-bed dorms, private twin rooms, and family-style en-suite rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R220 – R280; Private Rooms: From R650 – R850.



AFRICAN UBUNTU BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 8 Cherry Street, Wavecrest, Jeffreys Bay, 6330

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.03539,24.92896](#)

PHONE: [+27 42 296 0376](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 154 5313](#)

EMAIL: info@africanubuntu.co.za

WEBSITE: ubuntusunflodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf Lodge & Backpackers.

Features a mix of 6-bed mixed dorms, private twin/double rooms with shared bathrooms, and a private en-suite family unit with a kitchenette.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Beds: From R220 – R280; Private Rooms: From R600 – R900; Family/Self-Catering Unit: From R1,200 – R1,600.



THE LITTLE HOUSE ON SUPERS AT SUPERTUBES

STREET ADDRESS: 14 Pepper Street, Jeffreys Bay, 6330

GOOGLE MAPS: [-34.0315,24.93193](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 855 0341](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 855 0341](#)

EMAIL: info@stayinginbay.co.za

WEBSITE: littlehouseonsupers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4/ 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.7 / 10 ("Pleasant")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Self-Catering Beach House & Homestay. Offers a 3-bedroom main house (sleeps 7) and a separate 2-bedroom cottage (Pepper Street Cottage, sleeps 5).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Cottage/Rooms: From R650 – R1,200; Full House Rental: From R2,500 – R4,500 (Seasonal).



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

IKHAYALAM LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 25 Windermere Road, Humewood, Gqeberha, 6001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.97362,25.63884](#)

PHONE: [+27 41 582 5098](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 270 4968](#)

EMAIL: ikhayalamlodge@cybertrade.co.za

WEBSITE: ikhayalamlodgeandtours.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~5.3 / 10 ("Fair")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Functional Tour-Oriented Backpackers. A 3-star graded lodge offering a mix of 10-bed dorms, budget twin/double rooms, and self-catering studio units with private balconies.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R300; Double/Twin Rooms: From R750; Self-Catering Studios: From R950 – R1,100.

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LUNGILE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 12 La Roche Drive, Humewood, Gqeberha, 6001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.97881,25.64368](#)

PHONE: [+27 41 582 2042](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 237 0612](#)

EMAIL: info@lungilebackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: lungilebackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.7 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Upmarket Beachfront Backpackers. A spacious, high-ceilinged lodge offering 8-bed mixed dorms, 4-bed female-only dorms (en-suite), and various private rooms ranging from "Double Shared" to "Luxury En-suite."

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. 8-Bed Mixed Dorm: From R260; 4-Bed Female Dorm: From R340; Double Room (Shared Bath): From R720; Double Room (En-suite): From R840; Luxury Double: From R920.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

JIKELEZA LODGE BACKPACKERS HOSTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 44 Cuyler Street, Central, Gqeberha, 6001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.96609,25.61444](#)

PHONE: [+27 41 586 3721](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 734 8764](#)

EMAIL: info@jikelezalodge.co.za

WEBSITE: jikelezalodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.0 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Historic Urban Backpackers.

Set in an old heritage building with high ceilings and gleaming wood floors. Offers 6-7 bed mixed dorms, single privates, doubles, twins, and larger family/group rooms (up to 6 beds).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Mixed Dorm: From R245; Single Room (Shared Bath): From R405; Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R560; Family Room (4-6 sleeper): R1,060 – R1,470

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Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

THE HIPPO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 14 Glen Street, Richmond Hill, Gqeberha, 6001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.9587,25.60869](#)

PHONE: [+27 41 585 6350](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 752 0952](#)

EMAIL: fun@thehippo.co.za

WEBSITE: thehippo.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.8 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Social Garden Backpackers.

A large, converted Edwardian-style home in the trendy Richmond Hill suburb, offering mixed dorms and en-suite private doubles/twins focused on a "safari-first" experience.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Mixed Dorm: From R310; Private Double/Twin: From R750.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

RIVERFRONT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 18 Carden Street (or 28 Towpath), Red-house Village, Gqeberha, 6201

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.84093,25.57402](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 344 1941](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 344 1941](#)

EMAIL: 28towpath@gmail.com

WEBSITE: 28towpath.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.2 / 10 ("Superb")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dorms, private en-suite rooms, and self-catering units with a strong emphasis on permaculture and responsible tourism.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Mixed Dorm (4-bed): From R250; Single Room (Shared Bath): From R275; Double Room (Shared Bath): From R400; En-suite Riverfront Room: From R500; Cottage (Self-catering): From R990.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

WOODLANDS COTTAGES & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Grahamstown Road (R343), Kenton-on-Sea, 6191

PHONE: [+27 82 808 5976](tel:+27828085976) / [+27 46 648 2867](tel:+27466482867)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 808 5976](tel:+27828085976)

EMAIL: info@woodlandscottages.co.za

WEBSITE: woodlandscottages.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Lodge & Backpackers.

A lush, forested estate featuring diverse options from a basic dormitory and "Bush Camping" pitches to private, self-catering cottages and large group houses.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Bush Camping: From R175 per person. Dorm/Backpacker Rooms: From R250 – R350. Private Cottages: From R480 – R1,150.

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Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: GQEBERHA / PORT ELIZABETH

WILD WOODY CAPE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Main Street, Alexandria, 6185 (Located in the Woody Cape Section of Addo Elephant National Park)

PHONE: [+27 79 623 9644](tel:+27796239644) / [+27 46 653 0601](tel:+27466530601)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 623 9644](tel:+27796239644)

EMAIL: bookings@wildwoodycape.com

WEBSITE: wildwoodycape.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.8 / 10 "Good"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Nature Lodge & Backpackers. A rustic, eco-conscious retreat offering everything from a 10-bed dormitory and private "Budget Rooms" to fully equipped self-catering family chalets and grassy campsites.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Camping: From R150 – R200 per person; Dorm Bed: From R180 – R250; Double/Twin Rooms: From R600 – R800 per unit; Family Chalets: From R900 – R1,800 (depending on size/season).

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: PORT ALFRED

KOWIE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 13 Van Riebeeck Street, Port Alfred, 6170

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.59874,26.87537](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 266 8899](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 266 8899](#)

EMAIL: kowiebackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: kowiebackpackers.thinklocal.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~8.2 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Backpacker Hostel. It offers a mix of classic dormitory beds, basic private rooms, and a self-catering setup designed for communal living.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R220 – R280; Private Rooms: From R550 – R750.



HAMBURG BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 279 Main Road, Hamburg, 5641

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.29202,27.47286](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 874 4927](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 783 1288](#)

EMAIL: hamburgbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: canoetrails.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A (Operates primarily via direct booking and SafariNow)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Rustic Eco-Backpackers. The setup is off-the-grid, utilizing solar and gas power. It features three private rooms with en-suite bathrooms and a communal kitchen, as well as budget-friendly dormitory options.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R200 – R250; Private Rooms: From R500 – R750.



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: SUNSHINE COAST

City/Town: EAST LONDON

BUFFALO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 79 Moore Street, Quigney, East London, 5201

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.01294,27.91615](#)

PHONE: [+27 43 781 1122](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 401 4833](#)

EMAIL: buffalobackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: buffalobackpackers.yolasite.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~ 7.5 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Urban Backpackers. Offers a mix of basic dormitories, twin rooms, and double rooms centered around a communal courtyard.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R200 – R250; Private Rooms: From R450 – R600.



SUGARSHACK BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Eastern Esplanade Rd, Eastern Beach, Quigney, East London, 5201

GOOGLE MAPS: [-33.01006,27.92273](#)

PHONE: [+27 43 722 8240](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 74 890 8405](#)

EMAIL: sugarshack@iafrica.com

WEBSITE: sugarshack.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf-Centric Beach Backpackers. Housed in the original life-savers' building, it offers 12-bed dorms, double log cabins with private decks, and 3-to-4-bed family or group rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R300; Private Log Cabins/Twin Rooms: From R480 – R650.



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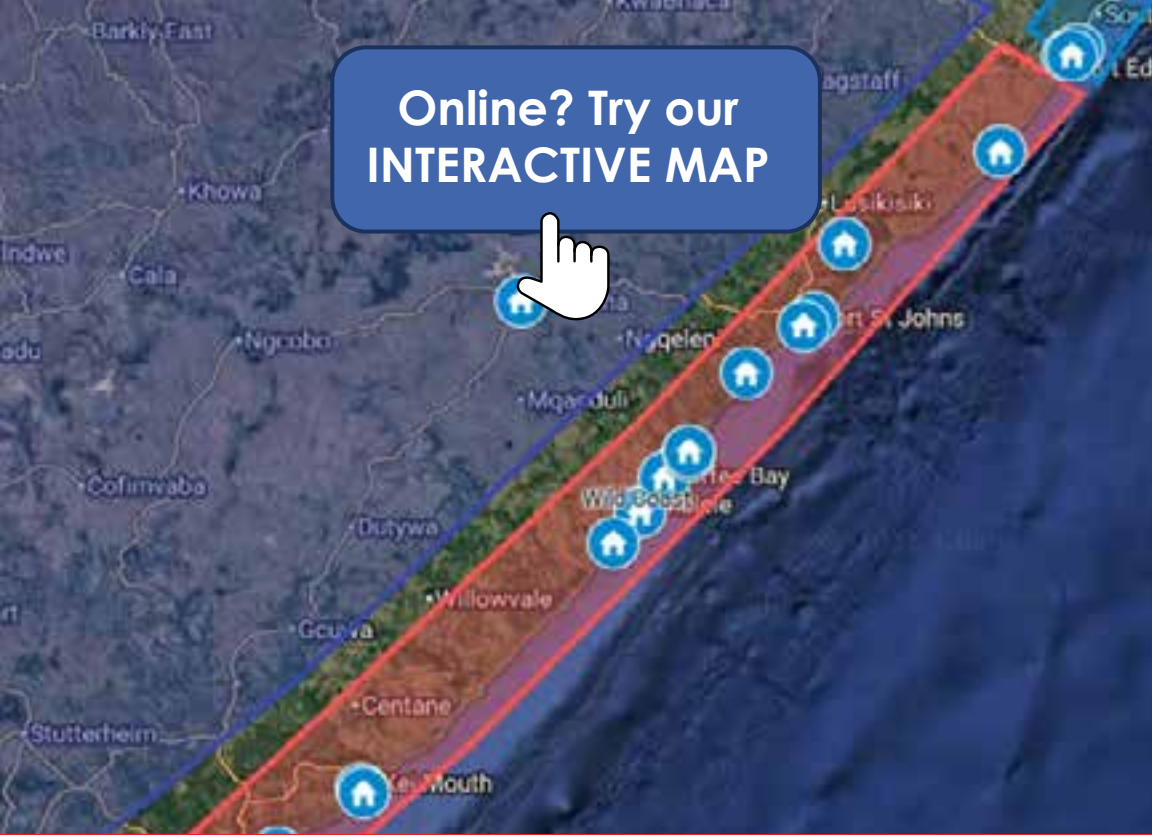
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BACKPACKING THE WILD COAST

The Wild Coast is South Africa's most dramatic and untamed stretch of coastline, running 280km from the Great Kei River to Port Edward. Free from major resorts and commercial chains, it is defined by emerald hills, cliff-edge lagoons, and the ancestral kingdom of the amaMpondo. It offers a sense of genuine discovery but requires travellers to be self-reliant and culturally informed.

The Layout: Two Halves of the Wild

The region is naturally divided by the Mthatha River:

The Southern Wild Coast: Home to the accessible hubs of Chintsa and Coffee Bay. This area is famous for the Hole in the Wall—a massive detached cliff with a central archway carved by the sea—and is the primary entry

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point for first-time visitors.

The Northern Wild Coast (Pondoland): Centred around Port St Johns, which sits dramatically between two towering cliffs known as “The Gates”. This region is more remote and culturally traditional, featuring world-class community-owned lodges like Bulungula and Mdumbi.

Backpacker Essentials

Culture and Etiquette: This is the heart of Mpondo culture. Respect is paramount: never photograph abakhwetha (initiates in white clay) or enter a homestead without an invitation. Note that while isiXhosa is the lingua franca, the amaMpondo are a distinct nation with their own royal house and identity.

Transport: A car with high ground clearance is strongly recommended, especially for the northern gravel roads. Shuttles run from East London to the main southern hostels, but the N2 transit through Mthatha requires caution—lock doors and avoid stopping.

Costs: This is South Africa's most affordable region. A daily budget of £20–£30 covers the basics. The legendary Wild Coast Hiking Trail (Coffee Bay to Port St Johns) is one of the world's best value multi-day walks.

The Sardine Run: In winter (June–July), billions of sardines migrate north, attracting thousands of dolphins, sharks, and whales. It is a world-class wildlife spectacle, though climate change is making its timing increasingly unpredictable.

Safety and Environment

Ocean Hazards: The “Wild” in the name refers to the sea. Rip currents are lethal, and Second Beach in Port St Johns is historically notorious for bull shark attacks. Do

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not swim there; use the tidal pools or calmer lagoons instead.

Crime Assessment: Following a wave of serious incidents in 2024, security has been bolstered through community and private initiatives. While the majority of visits are trouble-free, travellers should avoid driving at night, use reputable hostel transfers, and stay informed on local conditions.

Infrastructure: Expect “load shedding” (power cuts) and limited signal. Most lodges rely on solar and generators. Embrace the “digital detox.”

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Wild Coast](#)



WILD COAST HOSTELS

- [BUCCANEERS LODGE & BACKPACKERS](#)
- [IN THE GREEN BACKPACKERS](#)
- [COFFEE SHACK BACKPACKERS](#)
- [BULUNGULA LODGE](#)
- [WILD LUBANZI BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)
- [THE KRAAL BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MDUMBI BACKPACKERS](#)
- [VUKANI BACKPACKERS](#)
- [FREEDOM O CLOCK BACKPACKERS RETREAT](#)
- [AMAPONDO BACKPACKERS](#)
- [JUNGLE MONKEY BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MTHATHA BACKPACKERS & TOURS](#)



BUCCANEERS LODGE & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1 David Way, Chintsa West, 5275

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.83675,28.11023](#)

PHONE: [+27 43 734 3012](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 66 317 2858](#)

EMAIL: info@buccaneers.co.za

WEBSITE: buccaneers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Multi-Level Backpacker Resort.

A sprawling estate offering everything from basic dormitories and safari tents to luxury en-suite cottages and a "Tower" suite.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to High-End. Dorm Beds: From R280; Safari Tents: From R550; Private Luxury Cottages: Up to R1,800+.



IN THE GREEN BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 198 Tanglewood Road, Morgan Bay, 5292

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.70203,28.33727](#)

PHONE: [+27 76 981 3322](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 981 3322](#)

EMAIL: info@inthegreenbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: inthegreenbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.6 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-conscious Boutique Backpackers. A small, intimate establishment offering a mix of double rooms (with garden views), safari tents, and a 5-bed dormitory.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R150 – R200; Safari Tents: From R300; Private Double Rooms: From R350 – R450.



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: COFFEE BAY

COFFEE SHACK BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Coffee Shack Way, Coffee Bay, 5082

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.9888,29.14688](#)

PHONE: [+27 47 575 2048](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 656 4350](#)

EMAIL: happydays@coffeeshack.co.za

WEBSITE: coffeeshack.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dorms, Double Rooms (ron-davels), camping.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Beds: From R260;Camping: From R180;Private En-suite Rooms: From R825.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: NQILENI

BULUNGULA LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Nqileni Village, Xhora Mouth AA, Elliotdale District, 5070

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.14006,29.01036](#)

PHONE: [+27 47 577 8900](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 391 5525](#)

EMAIL: paradise@bulungula.com

WEBSITE: bulungula.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.1 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Community-Owned Eco-Lodge

PRICE RANGE: Budget (Extremely accessible). Dorm Beds: From R130; Camping: From R70; Traditional Huts (Double/Triple): From R330 - R420 per room.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: MAVALELENI

WILD LUBANZI BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Lubanzi Village, Mavaleleni Shinira, 5100

GOOGLE MAPS: [-32.06656,29.08305](#)

PHONE: [+27 78 530 8997](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 78 530 8997](#)

EMAIL: wild@lubanzi.co.za

WEBSITE: lubanzi.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Artistic Off-Grid Lodge.

A quirky collection of hand-built safari tents, a "Hobbit House," and a double-story dorm made from upcycled materials.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R145; Safari Tents: From R380 (for 2 people); Hobbit House (En-suite): From R650.

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THE KRAAL BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Mpande District, Tsweleni, Port St. Johns, 5120

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.75191,29.36769](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 871 4134](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 871 4134](#)

(Highly recommended as the only reliable way to reach them)

EMAIL: info@thekraalbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: thekraal.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Backpackers & Traditional Homestay.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: From R100; Dorm Beds (Traditional Hut): From R180; Private Huts: From R450.

VIBE-METER: 100% Primitive / 100% Tranquil



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: TSHANI

MDUMBI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Tshani Village, Mankosi A/A, Ngqeleni (near Port St. Johns), 5100

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.93964,29.21387](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 461 1834](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 461 1834](#)

EMAIL: mdumbi@mdumbi.co.za

WEBSITE: mdumbi.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Award-winning Community-Owned Eco-Hostel.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: From R150; Dorm Beds: From R220; Private Traditional Huts: From R550 – R750.

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VUKANI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Tshani Village, Mankosi A/A, Ngqeleni (near Mdumbi Beach), 5100

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.93658,29.20895](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 857 6989](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 857 6989](#)

EMAIL: stay@vukanibackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: vukanibackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Cultural Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: From R150; Dorm Beds: From R220; Private Rondavels (Ocean/Driftwood Room): From R550; Self-Catering Unit (Larnie Room): From R950 (sleeps up to 6).

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FREEDOM O CLOCK BACKPACKERS RETREAT

STREET ADDRESS: Mngcibe Village, Mdumbi River Mouth, 5140

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.92661,29.21429](#)

(Note: Be careful with GPS here; it often tries to take you to the wrong side of the river. Always follow the Mngcibe directions provided by the hosts.)

PHONE: [+27 76 610 9723](#) / [+27 72 948 7028](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 610 9723](#)

EMAIL: marleen@freedomoclock.co.za

WEBSITE: freedomoclock.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Minded Family-Run Retreat.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Range Budget. Camping: From R150; Dorm Beds / Hut: From R220; Private Rooms (Double/Family): From R550 – R750.



AMAPONDO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Erf 647, Second Beach Road, Port St. Johns, 5120

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.64438,29.52075](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 315 3103](#) / [+27 81 257 4504](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 315 3103](#)

EMAIL: info@amapondo.co.za

WEBSITE: amapondo.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.1 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Jungle-style Backpackers & Self-Catering Lodge.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Camping: From R150 (Note: No vehicle access to the campsite—tents only); Dorm Beds: From R220 – R250; Double/Twin Rooms: From R650; Self-Catering Cottages: From R850 – R1200.



Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: PORT ST JOHNS

JUNGLE MONKEY BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 3 Berea Rd, Port St Johns, 5120

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.62652,29.54502](#)

PHONE: [+27 47 564 1517](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 683 4595](#)

EMAIL: junglemonkeybp@gmail.com

WEBSITE: junglemonkeybackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.9 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Multi-level Backpackers & Lodge.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping: From R180; Dorm Beds: From R300; Safari Tents: From R350; Double/Twin Rooms: From R400.

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Province: EASTERN CAPE

Area: WILD COAST

City/Town: MTHATHA

MTHATHA BACKPACKERS & TOURS

STREET ADDRESS: 12 Aloe St, Fort Gale, Mthatha, 5099, Eastern Cape

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.5835, 28.7562](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 786 0441](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 786 0441](#)

EMAIL: mthathabackpackers@telkomsa.net

WEBSITE: mthathabackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Suburban Hostel & Guest Lodge. Mixed Dormitories (2, 3, and 4-sleeper options). Private Single & Double Rooms (En-suite available). Caravan Stay (2 single beds, shared bathroom). On-site Camping.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Camping from R150 (US\$10) per night, Dorm beds from R260 (US\$17). Private Double En-suite from R550 (US\$36). Prices may vary based on seasonal demand.

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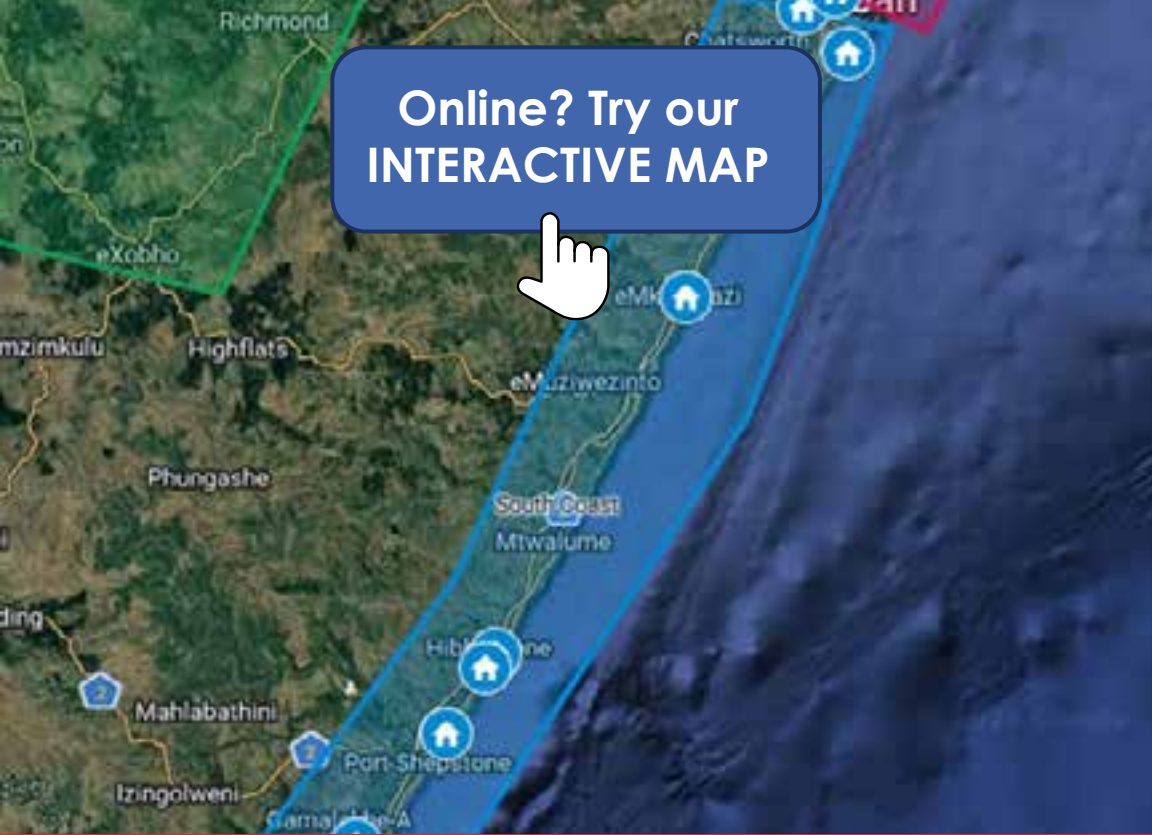
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BACKPACKING THE SOUTH COAST

The KwaZulu-Natal (KZN) South Coast is a 160km subtropical stretch running from Durban's southern outskirts to the Eastern Cape border. Characterised by lush sugar cane fields, warm Indian Ocean waters (22–27°C), and a string of unpretentious seaside towns, it remains a relatively undiscovered gem for international travellers.

The Layout: Subtropical Surf and Marine Life

Unlike the rugged Atlantic coast, the South Coast offers swimmable water year-round. It is a premier destination for marine enthusiasts, featuring:

Aliwal Shoal: Consistently ranked among the world's top ten dive sites, famous for shark encounters and whale sharks.

The Sardine Run: Occurring in June and July, this is the

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planet's largest biomass migration. It triggers a colossal feeding frenzy involving thousands of dolphins, sharks, and diving gannets.

Surf Culture: Towns like Umzumbe and Pumula host dedicated surf camps and hostels, offering world-class breaks with a laid-back, community feel.

Backpacker Essentials

Transport: For those starting in Durban, the Margate Mini Coach provides a reliable budget link to the central coast. However, a hire car is recommended for exploring the hidden beaches and inland gorges.

Costs: This is an exceptionally affordable region, even by South African standards. Dorm beds average £8–£12, and many hostels offer value-added surf or dive packages.

Timing: Winter (June–August) is the peak for marine life and consistent swell. Summer (November–March) is hot and humid, ideal for swimming but prone to afternoon thunderstorms and domestic holiday crowds.

Safety: Generally safer and slower-paced than South Africa's major cities. The primary risk is the ocean; always swim at beaches protected by the KZN Sharks Board nets and stay within lifeguarded flags due to strong rip currents.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking South Coast](#)

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SOUTH COAST HOSTELS

- [PUMULA SURF CAMP](#)
- [DRIFTWOOD BACKPACKING LODGE](#)
- [THE SPOT BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MANTIS AND MOON BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)
- [UMZUMBE SURF HOUSE & SURF CAMP](#)
- [ALI WAL DIVE CENTRE](#)
- [THE EARTHWORM MARGATE BACKPACKERS](#)

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BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: SOUTH COAST

City/Town: PUMULA

PUMULA SURF CAMP

STREET ADDRESS: 75 Park Avenue, Pumula, 4235, KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.63647,30.53214](#)

PHONE: [+27 68 740 4903](#) / [+27 39 684 5008](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 78 444 7130](#)

EMAIL: info@pumulasurfcamp.co.za

WEBSITE: pumulasurfcamp.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Surf House / Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm Beds: From R250. Twin Rooms: From R250 pppn sharing; Private Double Rooms: From R550; Rustic Bush Hut: From R350 (Basic, external bathrooms).

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DRIFTWOOD BACKPACKING LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 586 Seaton Avenue, Leisure Bay, 4278, KwaZulu-Natal (Approx. 5km from Port Edward)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-31.02441,30.2402](#)

PHONE: [+27 21 201 8901](#) / [+27 39 311 2333](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: reservations1@portedward.co.za

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 7.5 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Self-Catering Lodge / Large Group House.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range (Best for groups). Full Unit (Sleeps 8-10): From R2,100 per night; Per Person Rate: Effectively R210 - R300 pppn if the house is full.



THE SPOT BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 53 Ambleside Road, Umtentweni, Port Shepstone, 4235

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.71164,30.4795](#)

PHONE: [+27 39 695 1318](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 65 246 8347](#)

EMAIL: spotbackpackers@netactive.co.za

WEBSITE: spotbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.3 / 5 stars

TRIPADVISOR/TRIP.COM RATING: ~ 7.8 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Coastal Backpackers & Campsite.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Bed: From R220 – R280 pppn; Double/Twin Rooms: From R600 – R850 per room; Camping: From R120 – R150 pppn.



MANTIS AND MOON BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 178 Station Rd, Umzumbe, Port Shepstone, 4225

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.62436,30.54223](#)

PHONE: [+27 39 684 6256](#) / [+27 79 114 6609](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 114 6609](#)

EMAIL: info@mantisandmoon.net

WEBSITE: mantisandmoon.net

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 7.7 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Lodge / Jungle Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range; Dorm Bed: From R250 – R350 pppn; Handmade Cabins/Treehouses: From R950 – R1,500 per unit; Glass Cabins: From R1,200+ (Premium option).



UMZUMBE SURF HOUSE & SURF CAMP

STREET ADDRESS: 112 Station Road, Umzumbe, 4225, KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.61867,30.54545](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 352 6940](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 352 6940](#)

EMAIL: umzumbesurf@gmail.com

WEBSITE: umzumbesurfhouse.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.9 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Surf Lodge / Upscale Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range. Dorm Bed: From R300 – R400 pppn (Luxury 4-bed dorms); Private En-suite Rooms: From R1,100 – R1,800 per room.



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: SOUTH COAST

City/Town: UMKOMAAS

ALI WAL DIVE CENTRE

STREET ADDRESS: 2 Moodie St, Umkomaas, 4170

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.20702,30.80004](#)

PHONE: [+27 39 973 2233](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 893 2852](#)

[+27 82 842 9606](#)

EMAIL: dive@aliwalshoal.co.za

WEBSITE: aliwalshoal.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

BOOKINGS: [PADI Adventures](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

LEKKESLAAP RATING: ~4.1 / 5

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dive Lodge & Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorm Bed (Sleeps 4-6): From R350 pppn; Double/Twin En-suite Rooms: From R650 – R1,140 per room (Sea-facing options available).

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THE EARTHWORM MARGATE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 39 Wingate Avenue, Margate, 4275,
KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-30.83768,30.35708](#)

PHONE: [+27 76 424 4651](#) / [+27 84 812 5161](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 424 4651](#)

EMAIL: earthwormbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A (Listed primarily on niche
backpacker sites)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Backpackers & Garden
Lodge.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Bed: From R220 – R280
pppn; Private Rooms: From R600 – R800 per room;
Camping/Tent Sites: From R120 – R150 pppn.



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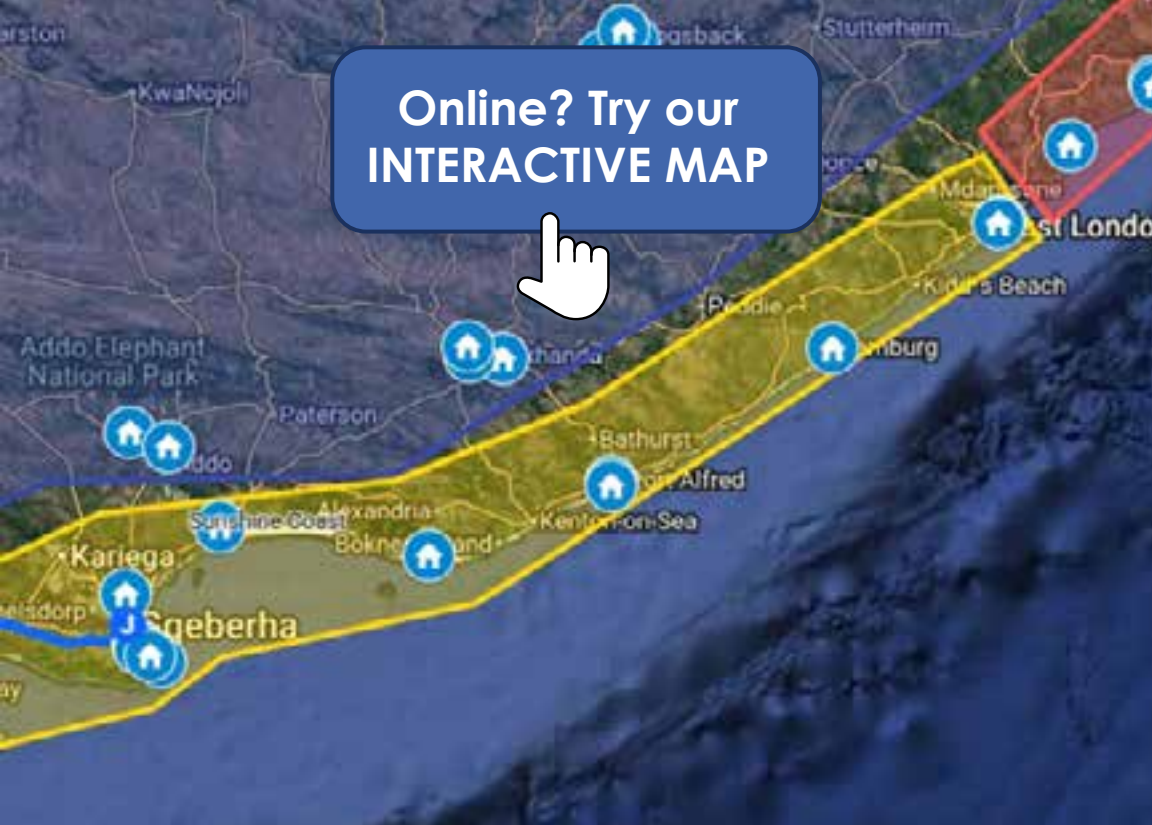
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BACKPACKING DURBAN

Durban is South Africa's premier subtropical city, defined by its lush greenery, warm Indian Ocean waters, and a complex cultural tapestry. Often underrated by international tourists, it serves as the country's economic heart-beat via Africa's busiest port and offers a more authentic, unpolished experience than Cape Town.

The Three Pillars of Durban's Identity

The English City: Founded with the intent to recreate England in Africa, Durban's colonial architecture (such as the City Hall) reflects this history. It was historically more liberal than other South African cities, having famously desegregated its beaches in the 1980s.

The Indian City: Home to the largest Indian community

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outside India, the city's food, architecture, and social fabric are deeply shaped by this heritage. The Bunny Chow (a hollowed-out loaf filled with curry) is the essential local culinary experience.

The Zulu City: As the gateway to KwaZulu-Natal, the city is a stronghold of Zulu culture and history, shaped by the legacy of King Shaka and the resistance against British colonial expansion.

Backpacker Hubs and Neighbourhoods

Morningside & The Berea: These are the most recommended areas for travellers. Leafy and hilly, they feature Florida Road, the city's social heart, filled with coffee shops, bars, and restaurants.

The Golden Mile: A famous beachfront promenade perfect for sunrise jogs. However, visitors should stay on the promenade itself and avoid the inland "flatland" blocks where crime is more prevalent.

Northern Beaches: For those seeking quiet, the uncrowded beaches north of Blue Lagoon offer warm water and fewer people, though they lack the infrastructure of the main strip.

Essential Travel AdviceSafety: Like all major South African cities, Durban requires "street intelligence." Avoid the CBD and the Point area (including Mahatma Gandhi Road) unless with a guide. Use Uber for transfers, especially after dark.

Water Quality: Ongoing sewage infrastructure issues can affect E. coli levels, particularly after heavy rain. Always check safety flags at beach entrances or municipal notices before swimming.

Climate: Winters (June–August) are sunny and mild,

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making them far more pleasant than the cold highveld or wet Cape winters. Summers are hot and humid with dramatic thunderstorms.

Transport: King Shaka International Airport is north of the city. Uber is the most efficient way to navigate between the Berea and the beachfront.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Durban](#)



DURBAN HOSTELS

- [ANSTEYS BEACH BACKPACKERS](#)
- [PEACEVALE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [GIBELA TRAVELLERS LODGE](#)
- [NOMADS BACKPACKERS](#)
- [AWEH AFRICA BACKPACKERS](#)
- [TEKWENI BACKPACKERS HOSTEL](#)
- [DURBAN BACKPACKERS - ON THE BEACH](#)



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: THE BLUFF

City/Town: DURBAN

ANSTEYS BEACH BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 477 Marine Drive, Bluff, Durban, 4052, KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.92319.31.01824](#)

PHONE: [+27 31 467 1192](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 807 6545](#)

EMAIL: info@ansteysbeach.co.za

ansteysreservations@gmail.com

WEBSITE: ansteysbeach.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.5 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Surf Lodge, Backpackers & Self-Catering Flats.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorm Bed: From R250 pppn; Budget Private Cabin (Shared Bath): From R550 – R650 per room; Private Rooms (En-suite): From R850+ per room.

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PEACEVALE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 132 Peacevale Road, Peacevale,
Drummond, 3626, KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.77755,30.70203](#)

PHONE: [+27 79 697 2881](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 697 2881](#)

EMAIL: bookings@peacevalegetaway.co.za

WEBSITE: peacevalegetaway.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 7.2 / 10 (Good)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Country Backpackers, Cottages & Group Getaway.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm/Daily Rates: From R300 pppn; Double Rooms: From R600 – R750 per room; Self-Catering Cottages: From R900 – R1,500+ (depending on size/sleepers).



GIBELA TRAVELLERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 119 Ninth Ave, Morningside, Durban, 4001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.83538,31.01456](#)

PHONE: [+27 31 303 6291](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 807 6545](#)

EMAIL: gibela@gibela.co.za

WEBSITE: gibelatravellerslodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Backpackers & Traveller's Lodge.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Range Budget. Dorm Bed: From R280 – R350 pppn; Private Room (Shared Bath): From R700 – R850 per room; En-suite Private: From R950+ per room.



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: BEREA

City/Town: DURBAN

NOMADS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 70 Stephen Dlamini Road (formerly Es-senwood Road), Musgrave, Durban, 4001, KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.8501,30.99806](#)

PHONE: [+27 31 202 9709](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 386 1618](#)

EMAIL: nomads@nomads.co.za

WEBSITE: nomads.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 7.5 / 10 (Good)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Traditional Adventure Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget-Friendly. Dorm Bed: From R180 – R250 pppn; Private Room (Shared Bath): From R480 – R550 per room; En-suite Private: From R650 – R750 per room.

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AWEH AFRICA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 121 Briar Lane, Park Hill, Durban North, 4051

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.7984, 31.02316](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 290 6063](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 290 6063](#)

EMAIL: info@awehafrica.com

WEBSITE: awehafrica.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 8.2 / 10 (Very Good)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Community Backpackers & Home-stay.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Bed: From R220 – R280 pppn; Private Double (Shared Bath): From R550 – R650 per room; En-suite Private: From R800+ per room.



TEKWENI BACKPACKERS HOSTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 169 Ninth Ave, Morningside, Durban, 4001

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.83354,31.01606](#)

PHONE: [+27 31 303 1433](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 31 303 1433](#)

EMAIL: info@tekwenibackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: tekwenibackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 5.6 / 10 ("Fair")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: High-Energy Traditional Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Bed: From R200 pppn; Standard Single (Shared Bath): From R500 per room; Standard Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R720 per room; Triple/Quad Rooms: From R720 – R960 per room.



DURBAN BACKPACKERS - ON THE BEACH

STREET ADDRESS: 17 The Promenade, Glenashley, Durban North, 4051

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.76249,31.06431](#)

PHONE: [+27 31 572 4054](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 456 1664](#)

EMAIL: stay@glenashleybeach.co.za

WEBSITE: glenashleybeach.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 7.7 / 10 ("Pleasant")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Beachfront Hostel & B&B Hybrid.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Range (Premium Location). Dorm Beds: From R350; Budget Single/Double: From R850 - R950; Deluxe Sea View Rooms: From R1,100 - R1,800.

VIBE-METER: 90% Coastal Chill / 10% Social Hub



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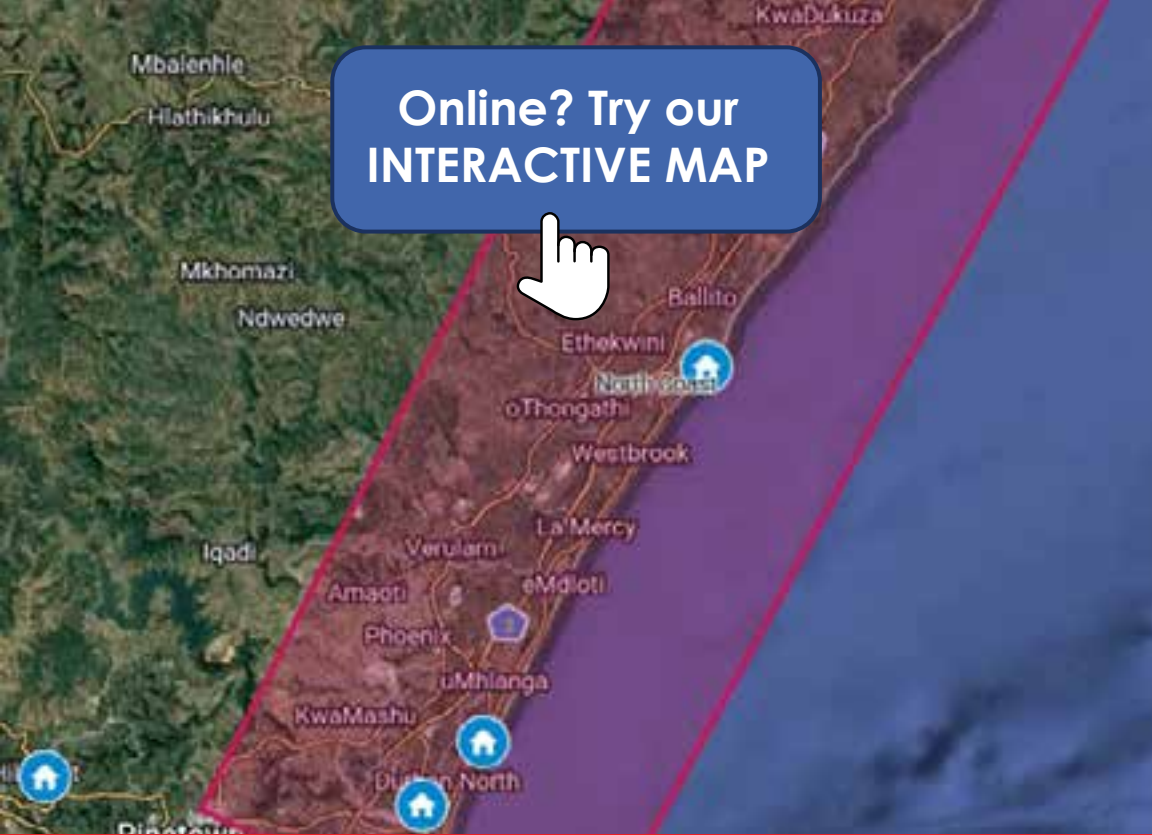
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A satellite map of the KwaZulu-Natal North Coast region in South Africa. A blue callout box with rounded corners is positioned in the upper center, containing the text 'Online? Try our INTERACTIVE MAP'. A white hand icon with a pointing finger is located just below the callout box, pointing towards the map. The map shows the coastline, major towns like Ballito, Durban, and Pietermaritzburg, and the Indian Ocean to the east.

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BACKPACKING THE NORTH COAST

The KwaZulu-Natal (KZN) North Coast, often called the Dolphin Coast, stretches from just north of Durban to the Tugela River. It is a subtropical landscape defined by rolling hills of sugarcane and the warm, swimmable Indian Ocean. Despite being just 30 minutes from King Shaka International Airport, it remains an underrated gem for backpackers, offering a blend of world-class history, wildlife, and arguably the best curry in the world.

The Layout: Sugar and Surf

The region is more relaxed and domestic than the dramatic Cape. Key towns include:

Ballito: The commercial hub with a growing food and surf scene.

Salt Rock & Shaka's Rock: Quieter villages known for

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magnificent tidal pools and royal Zulu history.

Zinkwazi: A lagoon-side village at the northern end, perfect for a slower pace.

A History of Indenture and Achievement

The North Coast's unique character is rooted in the sugar industry. In the 1840s, Zulu men, who viewed agricultural wage labour as culturally incompatible with their masculine identity, refused to work the cane fields. Consequently, between 1860 and 1911, over 152,000 indentured Indian labourers were brought to Natal. Despite brutal conditions and discriminatory laws, this community achieved a remarkable ascent. Today, South African Indians—roughly 1.4 million people—are among the most professionally and educationally represented groups in the country, deeply influencing KZN's legal, medical, and culinary landscapes.

The Legacy of Three Giants

The North Coast is a crucible of global history, home to the legacies of three iconic figures:

King Shaka: The founder of the Zulu Empire. You can visit his memorial and grave in KwaDukuza (Stanger). Shaka's Rock serves as a reminder of his coastal lookout points.

Mahatma Gandhi: Spent 21 years in South Africa. At the Phoenix Settlement, he developed Satyagraha (non-violent resistance). The site is a National Heritage Site and remains a "laboratory for ideas."

Chief Albert Luthuli: The first African Nobel Peace Prize laureate (1960) and ANC president. His home and museum in Groutville offer a poignant look at the struggle against apartheid.

Wildlife and Nature
Dolphins: Hundreds of bottlenose dolphins live here year-round and are fre-



quently visible surfing the waves.

The Sardine Run: Between May and July, billions of sardines migrate north, attracting thousands of dolphins, sharks, and gannets in a massive feeding frenzy. Whales: Humpback and Southern Right whales transit offshore from June to November.

The Ocean: Waters remain between 21–26°C year-round. Most main beaches are protected by the Natal Sharks Board nets, providing an excellent safety record.

Practical Essentials

Food: You must try a Bunny Chow (hollowed-out bread filled with curry). Local Durban Curry is distinctively red, hot, and complex.

Transport: A hire car is essential. While Uber works in Ballito, the historical sites and smaller beaches are best reached via the scenic, toll-free M4 coastal road.

Safety: Generally safer than Durban or Johannesburg, but “South African rules” apply: avoid walking at night, keep valuables out of sight, and swim only at lifeguarded beaches with shark nets.

Timing: Winter (June–August) is the sweet spot—dry, mild and ideal for witnessing the Sardine Run or whale watching.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking North Coast](#)



BALLITO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 22 Sandra Road, Ballito, 4420

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.54412,31.21414](#)

PHONE: [+27 32 946 0546](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 456 1664](#)

EMAIL: info@ballitobayholidays.co.za

WEBSITE: On Ballitoholidays.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.8 / 10 ("Pleasant")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: High-density Village Hostel & Semi Self-Catering Units.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R300; Budget Private (Double): From R650; Suites/Family Rooms: From R950.



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BACKPACKING THE MIDLANDS

The KwaZulu-Natal (KZN) Midlands is a high-altitude region of rolling green hills, dairy farms, and mist-covered valleys situated between the coastal belt and the Drakensberg foothills. While often bypassed by international travellers rushing to the mountains, it offers a sophisticated yet affordable escape with a cooler climate and a slower pace of life.

The Landscape: A Gateway to the Interior

The Midlands begins at the top of Town Hill, the escarpment above Pietermaritzburg (PMB), and extends north towards Mooi River. The region is defined by:

The Midlands Meander: South Africa's first craft route,

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established in 1985. It links independent artist studios, artisanal food producers (cheese, charcuterie, and trout), and scenic viewpoints.

Howick Falls: A “non-negotiable” stop where the Umgeni River plunges 95 metres over a basalt cliff.

The Mandela Capture Site: A historically significant landmark with a world-class museum marking where Nelson Mandela was arrested in 1962.

The Karkloof: Famous for its indigenous forests, canopy tours, and premier mountain biking trails.

Backpacker Hubs

Pietermaritzburg (PMB): The regional capital and a practical base for those using public transport. It features historic Victorian architecture and is generally cheaper than Durban.

Rural Lodges: Options like Riverside Manor in Rosetta or Summer Place in Estcourt provide a farmstay experience closer to the Meander’s heart.

Practical Essentials

Transport: A hire car or motorbike is essential for the Midlands. The Meander relies on back roads that are not served by minibus taxis. If you are without a vehicle, use PMB as a base for day trips.

Costs: Very budget-friendly. Dorm beds range from R180–R300 (£8–£13), and a high-quality artisanal lunch costs between R120 and R200.

Safety: The rural Midlands is among the safest areas in KZN. In PMB, standard urban precautions apply: use Uber at night and avoid flashing valuables in the CBD.

Timing: Autumn (March–May): The “pick of the seasons”



for gold-hued landscapes and clear air.

Winter (June–August): Genuinely cold with occasional snow, but dry and sunny.

Summer (November–February): Lush and green with dramatic afternoon thunderstorms.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Midlands](#)

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KWAZULU-NATAL MIDLANDS HOSTELS

- [PMB BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)
- [RIVERSIDE MANOR](#)
- [MSUNDUZI RIVER VIEW BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SUMMER PLACE BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)

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PMB BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 78 Leinster Rd, Scottsville, Pietermaritzburg, 3201

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.61692,30.39223](#)

PHONE: [+27 33 386 1957](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 232 4661](#)

EMAIL: info@pmbbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: pmbbackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~5.9 / 10 ("Fair")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Suburban House-Turned-Backpackers.

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorm Beds: From R220; Private Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R500; En-suite Units: From R650 - R800.



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: KZN MIDLANDS

Town: ROSETTA

RIVERSIDE MANOR

STREET ADDRESS: R103 Old Main Road, Rosetta, 3301

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.29712,29.97827](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 310 5632](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 310 5632](#)

EMAIL: enquiries@riversidemanor.co.za

WEBSITE: riversidemanor.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Riverside Estate with Dedicated Backpacker & Camping Wing.

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Range (Affordable Backpacker Options). Dorm Beds: From R240; Budget Units (Bunk-based Privates): From R280 - R350; Luxury Self-Catering Cottages: From R550 - R950;

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MSUNDUZI RIVER VIEW BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 51 Prince Alfred Street, Pietermaritzburg, 3201

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.61245,30.37568](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 677 9920](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 313 0998](#)

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

[SafariNow](#)

[Booking.com](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~4.8 / 10 "Disappointing"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Urban Backpacker Hostel with shared dormitory and private room configurations.

PRICE RANGE: Budget (Entry-level city pricing). Dorm Beds: From R200 - R250. Private Rooms (Twin/Double): From R400 - R500. Family/Group Rooms (4-5 Sleepers): From R1000 - R1250.



SUMMER PLACE BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: New Formosa Rd, Estcourt, 3310

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.02589,29.89033](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 677 9920](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 561 8996](#)

EMAIL: alel@summerplacelodge.co.za

WEBSITE: summerplacelodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Nature-Adjacent Guest Lodge with Dedicated Backpacker Cabins.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Backpacker Cabins (2 Sleepers): From R250 per person; En-suite Rooms (Private): From R450 - R600; Self-Catering Family Units: From R800 - R1200.



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The Little Berg: The lower foothills composed of pale Clarens sandstone, which erodes to form the caves and overhangs used for shelter and art.

The San: Africa's Oldest Artists

The mountains were the final stronghold of the San hunter-gatherers. They left behind over 40,000 paintings across 600 sites.

The Shamanic Portal: Archaeologists have decoded the art not as simple hunting scenes, but as records of shamanic trances. The rock face was viewed as a “membrane” between the physical and spirit worlds.

The Eland: The most sacred animal, believed to possess supernatural potency.

Key Sites: Giant's Castle (Main Caves), Injasuti (Battle Cave), and Kamberg (Game Pass Shelter). Note: All sites require an official guide; touching the art is strictly prohibited.

Navigating the Three Zones

Northern Drakensberg: Home to the Amphitheatre, a 5km-wide cliff wall, and Tugela Falls, arguably the world's tallest waterfall.

Central Drakensberg: A wilder region including Cathedral Peak and Giant's Castle. It offers the best multi-day hiking and the highest concentration of rock art.

Southern Drakensberg: Famous for the Sani Pass, the only road crossing into Lesotho. The pass requires a 4x4 and is a legendary “bucket list” drive.



Critical Safety and Seasonal Advice

The Drakensberg is beautiful but lethal to the underprepared.

Lightning (The Main Threat): The region has one of the world's highest lightning strike rates. In summer (Nov–Mar), violent afternoon storms are daily. Protocol: Be off the ridges and under cover by 2:00 PM.

Winter (Apr–Sept): The best time for hiking. The air is dry and crystal clear, though nights on the escarpment drop well below 0.

Essential Gear: Genuine waterproofs (not “water-resistant”), warm layers for sub-zero wind chill, and offline GPS maps.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Drakensberg](#)

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- [SANI LODGE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MOUNTAIN BASE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [BERG BACKPACKERS](#)
- [AMPHITHEATRE BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)

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KHOTSO LODGE & HORSE TRAILS

STREET ADDRESS: Drakensberg Gardens Road, Underberg, 3257

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.74596,29.4264](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 412 5540](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 412 5540](#)

EMAIL: info@khotso.co.za

WEBSITE: khotso.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.4 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Adventure Farm with Backpackers Lodge, Rondavels, and a Massive Log Cabin.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Camping: From R190 per person; Backpacker Dorms: From R360 per person; Private Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R1,100 per room; En-suite Rooms: From R1,300 per room; Self-Catering Rondavels: From R1,600 (base rate for 2).



SANI LODGE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 10.5 km along Sani Pass road, Mkhomazi Wilderness area, Southern Drakensberg, Himeville, 3257

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.66232,29.45614](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 987 3071](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 987 3071](#)

EMAIL: info@sanilodge.co.za

WEBSITE: sanilodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.9 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Fair Trade Tourism Certified Eco-Lodge with dorms, rooms, rondavels, and cottages

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Backpacker Dorms: From R350 - R400 per person; Private Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R950 per room; Standard Rondavels (En-suite): From R1,350 per room, Self-Catering Cottages: From R2,000 per night (sleeps 4).



MOUNTAIN BASE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: R600 Cathkin Road, Champagne Valley, Central Drakensberg (adjacent to Dragon Peaks Resort)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.01608,29.43671](#)

PHONE: [+27 36 468 1031](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 81 479 8195](#)

EMAIL: info@mountainbase.co.za

WEBSITE: mountainbase.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.6 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Adventure Base and Backpackers (revamped from the old airfield mountain base). Dorms, cabins, rooms.

PRICE RANGE: Very Budget-Friendly. Dorms: From R165 (Low Season) to R220 (High Season) per person; Private Cabins (Shared Bath): From R225 (Low Season) to R300 (High Season) per person; En-suite Rooms: From R295 (Low Season) to R400 (High Season) per person.



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: DRAKENSBERG

City/Town: WINTERTON

BERG BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Glen Gray Farm, R600, Winterton, 3340

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.82754,29.47028](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 400 3724](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 400 3724](#)

EMAIL: info@bergbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: [on Drakensberg Hikes](#)

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.4 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Farm-stay Backpackers (No Dorms - Private Rooms only).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Private Double/Twin (Shared Bath): From R500 per room; Family Rooms (Private Bath): From R900 per room.

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AMPHITHEATRE BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: R74, Northern Drakensberg, Bergville, 3350

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.64329,29.15882](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 855 9767](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 855 9767](#)

EMAIL: bookings@amphibackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: amphibackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 6.3 / 10 "Okay"

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Full-service Adventure Hostel (Dorms, Privates, Safari Tents, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-Range Budget. Camping: From R135 per person; Dorms: From R295 per person; Private Double (En-suite): From R820 - R1,080 per room.



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: DRAKENSBERG

City/Town: PHUTHADITJHABA

MALUTI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 3232 Nteo Street, Phuthaditjhaba-A,
Phuthaditjhaba, 9866, Free State, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.51372, 28.81858](#)

PHONE: [+27 76 193 4444](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 193 4444](#)

EMAIL: bookings@malutibackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: malutibackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: 5.3 / 10 "Fair"

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BACKPACKING ZULULAND

Zululand, the northern region of KwaZulu-Natal, is a landscape where human history and wild nature are inextricably linked. From the subtropical iSimangaliso Wetland Park to the historic battlefields of the interior, it offers a “raw” experience defined by ancient Zulu traditions and successful wildlife conservation.

The Zulu Nation: History and Culture

The Zulu are South Africa's largest ethnic group. Their identity was forged in the early 19th century by King Shaka, who revolutionised African warfare with the *iklwa* (stabbing spear) and the *impondo zankomo* (bull horn) formation.

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Key Historic Events:

The Mfecane (“The Crushing”): A period of widespread displacement and warfare caused by Shaka’s expansion, which reshaped the demographics of Southern Africa.

Battle of Blood River (1838): A Voortrekker force of 470 defeated 10,000–15,000 Zulu warriors. The Ncome River reportedly ran red with blood, a day now commemorated as the Day of Reconciliation.

Isandlwana (1879): The British Army’s greatest defeat against an indigenous force, where 20,000 Zulu warriors killed over 1,300 soldiers.

Rorke’s Drift (1879): Immediately following Isandlwana, 150 British soldiers successfully defended a mission station against 3,000–4,000 Zulu, resulting in a record 11 Victoria Crosses.

Wildlife: The Cradle of the White Rhino

Zululand is home to the Hluhluwe-iMfolozi Game Reserve, the oldest in Africa. In the early 20th century, the southern white rhino population had dwindled to fewer than 50 individuals. Through pioneering conservation here, the global population has recovered to over 17,000.

Ecological Highlights:

iSimangaliso Wetland Park: A UNESCO World Heritage site featuring hippos, crocodiles, and over 530 bird species.

Sodwana Bay: The world’s southernmost tropical coral reef and South Africa’s premier diving spot.

Tembe Elephant Park: Home to the largest free-ranging “Tusker” bulls in Africa.

Mkuze Game Reserve: A “hidden gem” for birders, with



over 400 recorded species.

Zululand's Secrets

Ghost Mountain (iNtaba yaMapunga): A sacred, symmetrical granite peak near Mkuze steeped in Zulu legend and site of a bloody 1884 succession battle.

Living Culture: In towns like Eshowe, visitors can engage with modern Zulu life, including sangomas (traditional healers) and the annual Reed Dance (umkhosi woMhlanga).

Practical Essentials

Transport: A car is almost mandatory. St Lucia is the only hub accessible via the Baz Bus; other sites like Sodwana or Kosi Bay require independent wheels.

Health: The Zululand coast is a Malaria zone. Prophylactics are strongly advised, especially in summer (Oct–Apr).

Safety: While generally low-risk, exercise caution at isolated spots like 9 Mile Beach (Sodwana), where robberies have been reported. Never swim in inland rivers due to crocodiles and hippos.

Best Time to Visit: Winter (June–Sept) offers the best game viewing and whale watching. Summer (Nov–Feb) is peak turtle-nesting season on the beaches.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Zululand](#)

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- [ISINKWE SAFARIS BUSH CAMP](#)
- [CORAL DIVERS](#)
- [NATURAL MOMENTS BUSH CAMP & DIVING](#)
- [THOBEKA BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)
- [BIBS INTERNATIONAL BACKPACKERS](#)



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: ESHOWE

ZULULAND BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 36 Pearson Avenue, Eshowe, 3815,
KwaZulu-Natal

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.88421,31.45582](#)

PHONE: [+27 35 474 4919](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 492 6918](#)

EMAIL: info@eshowe.com

WEBSITE: eshowe.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-conscious Cultural Hostel
(Dorms, Private Rooms, and Self-Catering).

PRICE RANGE: Budget Friendly. Dorms: From R250 per
person; Private Rooms: From R650 - R850 per room.

VIBE-METER: 80% Cultural Immersion / 20% Tropical Gar-
den Chill

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Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: ST LUCIA

MONZI SAFARIS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 81 Mckenzie Street, St Lucia, 3936, Kwa-Zulu-Natal, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.37729.32.41098](#)

PHONE: [+27 35 590 1555](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 79 367 0134](#)

EMAIL: info@monzisafaris.com

WEBSITE: monzisafaris.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: [Facebook](#)

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.9 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Backpackers & Tented Camp (Luxury Dorms, Tented Units, and En-suite Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorms: From R220 – R290 per person; Luxury Dome Tents: From R550 – R750 per unit; Private Rooms: From R900 – R1,200 per room.

VIBE-METER: 80% Tropical Safari Lounge / 20% Upscale Social Hub

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Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: HLUHLUWE

ISINKWE SAFARIS BUSH CAMP

STREET ADDRESS: D123 Road, Bushlands, Hluhluwe, 3960, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.10871,32.28438](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 677 9920](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: reception@isinkwe.co.za

WEBSITE: isinkwe.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.9 / 5 stars (based on ~25 reviews)

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 5.9 / 10 ("Okay") (varies by room type; indicative of basic facilities)

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Rustic self-catering and ensuite rooms, basic shared facilities and camping options.

PRICE RANGE: Bushbaby Self-Catering Tree Cabin: approx R1050 for 2 adults sharing (breakfast included); Cicada & Genet Ensuite Rooms: approx R850 for 2 adults sharing (breakfast included); Longhorn Beetle Twin Room: approx R700 for 2 adults (breakfast included);- Camping: approx R150 per person per night.

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Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: SODWANA

CORAL DIVERS

STREET ADDRESS: Coral Divers Resort, Camp F, KZN Wildlife Park, Sodwana Bay, iSimangaliso Wetland Park, Mbazwana, 3974, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-27.55446,32.6667](#)

PHONE: [+27 33 345 6531](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: bookings@coraldivers.co.za

WEBSITE: coraldivers.co.za

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.4 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: A mix of budget safari tents, standard cabins and ensuite cabins, all within a social resort environment.

PRICE RANGE: Safari tents - budget-friendly, rustic accommodation; Standard cabins – mid-range, often with shared bathroom facilities; Ensuite cabins - higher comfort with private facilities.

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NATURAL MOMENTS BUSH CAMP & DIVING

STREET ADDRESS: Plot 1A, Sodwana Bay, Mbazwana, 3974, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-27.51447.32.65806](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 236 1756](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 236 1756](#)

EMAIL: natural.moments.sodwana@gmail.com

WEBSITE: divesodwana.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget bush camp & simple dive-focused accommodation - rustic self-catering rooms, en-suite options, family units, backpacker rooms and an eco-style campsite with basic facilities.

PRICE RANGE: Backpacker dorm/basic cabin from around R110 per person per night; Family units ~R1 200+ per unit (varies by season); Camping sites also available (bring own gear).



Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: KOSI BAY

THOBEKA BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Kosi Bay Road, Star Mission Village, 3973

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.95779,32.77592](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 446 1525](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 446 1525](#)

EMAIL: info@kosi.co.za

WEBSITE: kosi.co.za

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers Lodge (Dorms, private rooms, family rooms and camping) — simple self-catering and communal social spaces under shade trees, typical of a laid-back backpacker base in rural Kosi Bay.

PRICE RANGE: Basic dormitory rooms from roughly R400+ per night; Private twin/double and family rooms also available.

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Province: KWAZULU-NATAL

Area: ZULULAND

City/Town: SAINT LUCIA

BIBS INTERNATIONAL BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 310 McKenzie Street, St Lucia Estuary,
3936, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.37925.32.40991](#)

PHONE: [+27 35 590 1360](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: bookings@bibs.co.za

WEBSITE: bibs.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE / HOSTELWORLD RATING: ~ 7.4 / 10

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Hostel Accommodation – Dorm rooms and basic self-catering facilities, with some self-catering chalets noted on the official site.

PRICE RANGE: Dorm beds and shared rooms – budget backpacker rates (often cheapest in St Lucia, subject to season and availability); Self-catering chalets and family units available via website direct enquires.

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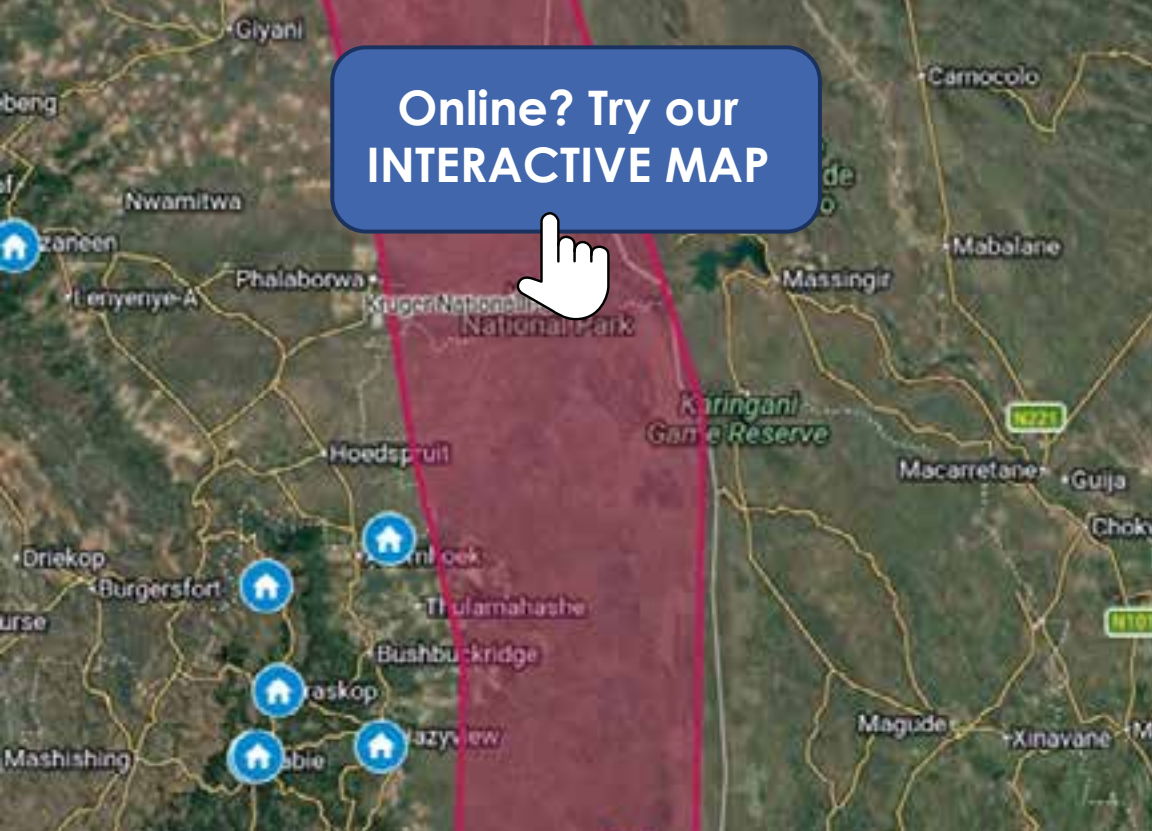
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BACKPACKING KRUGER, MPUMALANGA & LIMPOPO

This guide covers the northeastern circuit of South Africa: Mpumalanga, Limpopo, and the Kruger National Park. This region is a “stacked” landscape where the high-altitude escarpment drops into the subtropical Lowveld, offering the world’s premier safari experience alongside ancient human history.

The Big Picture: Three Regions, One Journey

The northeastern corner of South Africa is defined by the Drakensberg Escarpment. To the west lies the cool Highveld; to the east, the escarpment plunges over 1,000 metres into the Lowveld, a vast wilderness containing the Kruger National Park and extending into Mozambique.

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Mpumalanga: “The Place of the Rising Sun.”

Home to the dramatic Panorama Route.

Limpopo: South Africa’s northern frontier.

Famous for baobabs, ancient kingdoms, and “untouristed” bush.

Kruger National Park: The size of Wales

Stretching across both provinces from the Crocodile River to the Limpopo River.

1. The Panorama Route (Mpumalanga)

This is a world-class driving route along the R532 and R534. It is best explored using Graskop or Sabie as a base.

The “Big Three” Sights

Blyde River Canyon: The world’s third-largest canyon and the largest “green” canyon.

The Three Rondavels: Three massive, beehive-shaped rock peaks rising from the canyon floor.

God’s Window: A viewpoint on the escarpment edge with a vertical drop of over 700 metres, offering views across the Lowveld to Mozambique.

Itinerary Tip: Start at Bourke’s Luck Potholes at 7:00 AM to catch the morning light, move to the Three Rondavels, then hit God’s Window before finishing with a famous pancake in Graskop.

2. The Kruger National Park

Kruger is a well-oiled conservation machine. While the south (near Skukuza) is the most popular, the Northern Kruger (Limpopo side) offers a much quieter, more rug-



ged experience.

Self-Drive vs. Guided: You can drive a standard hatchback on the park's tar and gravel roads. However, a guided open-vehicle safari (approx. R650–R1,200) is recommended at least once for expert animal tracking.

The “Golden Hours”: Animals are most active the first two hours after gate opening and the last two hours before closing.

Costs: Daily conservation fees for internationals are approx. R480.

Safety: You must be inside a camp or out of the gate by closing time (varies by season between 5:30 PM and 6:30 PM) or face heavy fines.

3. Limpopo: The Ancient North

Limpopo is where you go for “deep” Africa—culture, silence, and scale.

Baobabs: The northern Lowveld is dotted with these 3,000-year-old giants. Look for the Sagole Big Tree, South Africa's largest baobab.

Mapungubwe (UNESCO Site): The site of Southern Africa's first complex kingdom. The “Golden Rhinoceros” was discovered here.

Venda Heartland: A region of sacred lakes (like Lake Fundudzi) and living traditions. Always visit with a local guide to respect spiritual protocols.

The Waterberg: A massive sandstone plateau that is Malaria-free, making it a great alternative for Big Five viewing without medication.

Practical Essentials for Backpackers

Transport: A hire car is non-negotiable for this region. Public transport exists between towns but does not reach



(About Backpacking Kruger, Mpumalanga & Limpopo)

viewpoints, waterfalls, or game reserve gates. Pick up a car at Johannesburg (OR Tambo) or Polokwane.

Health: The Malaria Reality

The Lowveld (including Kruger, Hazyview, and Phalaborwa) is a Malaria zone.

Prophylactics: Consult a doctor about Doxycycline or Malarone.

Prevention: Wear long sleeves at dusk and use DEET-based repellent.

Note: The high-altitude towns of Graskop and the Waterberg are generally safe/low-risk.

Timing & Climate

Winter (May–August): Best for wildlife. The bush is thin, and animals congregate at waterholes. Nights are cold; days are mild.

Summer (November–February): Lush and green with dramatic thunderstorms. Excellent for birding, but can be oppressively hot in the Lowveld.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Kruger](#)

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KRUGER, MPUMALANGA & LIMPOPO HOSTELS

- [ERMELO BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SHIK SHACK TOURS & BACKPACKERS](#)
- [KRUGER INN BACKPACKERS](#)
- [HAZYVIEW ADVENTURE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [VALLEY VIEW BACKPACKERS GRASKOP](#)
- [SABIE BACKPACKERS](#)
- [BILLY BONGO BACKPACKERS](#)
- [OLD VIC TRAVELLERS INN](#)
- [KRUGER VIEW BACKPACKERS](#)
- [MODIMOLLE FUNKY STAY BACKPACKERS](#)
- [SATVIK BACKPACKERS](#)

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: ERMELO

ERMELO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 6 Murray Street, Ermelo, 2350, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.526.29.9833](#)

PHONE: [+27 17 819 7101](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 821 5722](#)

EMAIL: info@ermelobackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: ermelobackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.5–8.0 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers Hostel**

- Dormitory rooms, en-suite room, self-catering log cabin and mixed shared facilities.

PRICE RANGE: Dorm beds from around R248 per night (single dorm) and R496+ per night for multi-bed dorms; En-suite rooms and log cabins from approx R460–R483 per night for two people.



Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: HOEDSPRUIT

SHIK SHACK TOURS & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Off the R531 Orpen Road, Sigagule Village, Acornhoek, 1380, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-24.56418,31.13201](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 662 0970](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 662 0970](#)

EMAIL: tourism@nourishecovillage.com

WEBSITE: shikshack.com

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: Available when searched but sometimes inconsistent

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Eco-Cultural Retreat - safari tents, traditional huts, teepees and community-style lodgings with access to communal facilities.

PRICE RANGE: Approx R468–R660 per night for tented and hut accommodation.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: KRUGER

City/Town: MARLOTH PARK

KRUGER INN BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 2007 Olifant Drive, Marloth Park, 1340, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.35146.31.77163](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 673 8484](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 673 8484](#)

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: [krugerinnbackpackers.com](#)

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 8.5 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Guest-house - a mix of dormitory and private rooms, self-catering kitchen, communal lounge and outdoor spaces, set within the wildlife-rich Marloth Park community.

PRICE RANGE: Budget shared dorms and private rooms available - average from around R350+ per night for 2 sharing

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: KRUGER

City/Town: HAZYVIEW

HAZYVIEW ADVENTURE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Route R40 (White River Road), Numbi Park, Hazyview, 1240, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.06555,31.1081](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 859 0212](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 859 0212](#)

EMAIL: hazyviewadventure@gmail.com

WEBSITE: hazybackpack.weebly.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: Approx 8.0+ /10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dorm rooms, en-suite eco units, wooden cabins, family rooms, dome tents, and caravan/camping spaces under lush indigenous trees.

PRICE RANGE: Rooms from around R620 per night (2 sharing) upwards, depending on type (wooden cabins, Bamboo Suite, Zebra Suite, family unit etc.); Dorm beds and camping can be more budget-friendly; family and suite units cost more.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: GRASKOP

VALLEY VIEW BACKPACKERS GRASKOP

STREET ADDRESS: 47 De Lange Street, Graskop, 1270, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-24.9335,30.83443](#)

PHONE: [+27 84 299 0423](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 299 0423](#)

EMAIL: valleyviewbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: valley-view.co.za

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Self-Catering Accommodation - offers a mix of dormitory beds, private rooms, self-catering rondavels, wooden cabins and camping space

PRICE RANGE: Budget: Dorms and basic units from around R200 per person per night; private rooms and cabins roughly R300–R460+; self-catering rondavels ~R550 per night.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: SABIE

SABIE BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 185 Main Road, Sabie, 1260, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-24.9335,30.83443](#)

PHONE: [+27 13 764 2118](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 268 1093](#)

EMAIL: sabiebackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: www.sabiebackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Hostel & Backpackers (Dormitory beds and basic private rooms; simple, social spaces) — focused on backpackers, overlanders and adventure travellers.

PRICE RANGE: Very budget-friendly. Website lists a base rate of ≈R75 per person per night for backpacker beds (first-come, first-serve) — one of the lowest in the area.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: SABIE

BILLY BONGO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 176 Ou Lydenburg Road, Sabie, 1260, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.09558,30.76873](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 370 7219](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.4 / 5 stars*

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers Hostel & Rustic Lodge - simple shared dorms, basic private units, garden and communal areas with a laid-back vibe.

PRICE RANGE: Budget backpackers pricing - historically around R300–R400+ per night



Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: KRUGER

City/Town: MBOMBELA

OLD VIC TRAVELLERS INN

STREET ADDRESS: 12 Impala Street, Mbombela (Nelspruit),
1200, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.49391,30.98576](#)

PHONE: [+27 13 744 0993](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 340 1508](#)

EMAIL: oldvic@mweb.co.za

WEBSITE: oldvictravellersinn.com

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~ 7.5 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Dorm beds, budget private rooms, en-suite rooms, self-catering units and larger family/cottage units.

PRICE RANGE: Dorm-style beds from about R295 per person per night; Budget private rooms ~R590–R600 per night for two sharing; En-suite and self-catering units can range R900+ up to ~R1 200+ depending on room size and season.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: KRUGER

City/Town: KOMATIEPOORT

KRUGER VIEW BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 61 Bosbok Street, Komatipoort, 1340, Mpumalanga, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.42708,31.96082](#)

PHONE: [+27 73 445 9665](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@krugerview.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Backpackers Hostel & Lodge (mixed dorm, private rooms and cabin-style options; scenic river views toward Kruger National Park).

PRICE RANGE: Moderate budget. Prices vary seasonally but typically backpacker-level rates apply for shared accommodation; private rooms and cabins command higher rates.

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Province: MPUMALANGA

Area: MPUMALANGA

City/Town: MODIMOLLE

MODIMOLLE FUNKY STAY BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: R101, Section 29, 0510, Modimolle, Limpopo, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-24.67519,28.44166](#)

PHONE: [+27 14 004 0131](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA: N/A

GOOGLE RATING: ~ 3.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers/Guest-house with private rooms and basic shared facilities.

PRICE RANGE: Budget-friendly. Room rates vary seasonally; typical listings show modest pricing (e.g., around ZAR 290+ for basic rooms)

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Province: LIMPOPO

Area: LIMPOPO

City/Town: TZANEEN

SATVIK BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: GV72 Georges Valley Road, R528, Tzaneen, 0850, Limpopo, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-23.84465,30.12393](#)

PHONE: [+27 15 307 3920](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@satvik.co.za

WEBSITE: satvik.co.za

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Rustic Backpackers & Self-Catering (Dorm rooms, en-suites, family cottages, camping/caravan sites) on a nature reserve beside the water.

PRICE RANGE: Budget to mid-range – Dorm beds advertised from around R180 pppn; private units and cottages from roughly R480–R1150+ per night (varies by season).

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BACKPACKING JOHANNESBURG

This guide to Johannesburg (Joburg) follows a “hub-and-spoke” model. Unlike Cape Town, Joburg is a city of layers and contradictions that rewards deliberate, informed travel. It is a sprawling metropolis where safety is managed by staying within secure “hubs” and using transport to move between them.

1. The Hub-and-Spoke Model

You cannot walk between neighbourhoods in Johannesburg. To navigate the city successfully, choose a safe hub as your base and travel to other spokes (sights) via Uber or the Gautrain.

Recommended Bases for Backpackers

Rosebank: The most logical base for first-timers. It is up-

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scale, walkable within its boundaries, and has a direct Gautrain link to the airport.

Melville: The bohemian soul of the city. Known for 7th Street's bars, bookshops, and unpretentious social scene. Ideal for longer stays.

Maboneng: A creative "island" in the inner city full of galleries and rooftop bars. Warning: Stay strictly within the precinct boundaries; the surrounding blocks are high-risk.

Soweto: For total immersion, stay at Lebo's Soweto Backpackers. It offers a deeper cultural experience than a standard day trip.

2. Essential Experiences

The Apartheid Museum: Essential for understanding the "frequency" the rest of the country is broadcast on.

Soweto: Africa's largest township. Visit the Hector Pieter-son Memorial and Vilakazi Street (where both Mandela and Tutu lived). Always go with a guide or a community-based operator.

The Music Scene: Joburg is the birthplace of Kwaito and the global home of Amapiano. Check out the jazz scene in Braamfontein or clubs in Soweto.

The Markets: The Rosebank Sunday Market and Maboneng's weekend markets offer world-class food and local crafts.

3. Practical Essentials

Transport & Arrival

Gautrain: A world-class, safe train connecting the airport to Rosebank and Sandton in 30 minutes.

Uber/Bolt: The non-negotiable tool for moving between suburbs. It is cheap (€2–€4 per trip) and safer than me-



tered taxis.

Park Station Warning: If arriving by long-distance bus, do not walk outside the station. Book your Uber from inside the building and go directly to the car.

Climate & Timing

Altitude: At 1,750m, Joburg is not a typical “tropical” city.

Summer (Oct–March): Hot with spectacular afternoon thunderstorms.

Winter (June–Aug): Dry and sunny, but nights often drop to freezing. Pack layers.

The Jacaranda Season: In October/November, the city’s massive man-made forest turns purple with blossoms.

Costs (Budget-Friendly)

Joburg offers high value for European and UK travellers.

Dorm bed: £10–£18

Sit-down meal: £5–£10

Craft beer: £1.50–£2.50

4. Safety & Etiquette

Joburg has a serious crime problem, but most incidents are avoided with common sense:

Visual Awareness: Do not consult your phone on street corners.

The 48-Hour Rule: Give the city at least four days; those who treat it as a one-night transit stop rarely see its best side.

Load Shedding: Download the EskomSePush app to track scheduled power cuts. Most hostels have backup power.

Inequality: The city doesn’t want your guilt; it wants your attention. Support locally owned businesses and tip di-



rectly.

Summary Tip: If you are nervous, start in Rosebank. Use the Gautrain from the airport, enjoy the mall and local cafes, and use Uber to explore Melville and Soweto. You will quickly find that the “fear” of Joburg is easily managed by following the rules.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Johannesburg](#)



JOHANNESBURG HOSTELS

EAST (AIRPORT PROXIMITY)

- [BACKPACKERS CONNECTION](#)
- [BROWN SUGAR BACKPACKERS](#)
- [GEMINI BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)
- [MIKASA SUKASA BACKPACKERS](#)
- [TERRYLINN BACKPACKERS HOSTEL](#)
- [LAKEVIEW BACKPACKERS](#)

NORTH

- [ACCOUSTIX LODGE & BACKPACKER](#)
- [JOBURG BACKPACKERS](#)
- [EXPLORER BACKPACKERS](#)
- [ROSEBANK BACKPACKERS](#)

CENTRAL

- [CURIOCITY BACKPACKERS](#)

SOWETO

- [LEBO'S SOWETO BACKPACKERS](#)



BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: GAUTENG

Area: SOWETO

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

LEBO'S SOWETO BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 10823 Poee St, Orlando West, Johannesburg, 1804

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.22454,27.91307](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 936 3444](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 81 524 2918](#)

EMAIL: lebo@sowetobackpackers.com

WEBSITE: sowetobackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.1 / 10 ("Wonderful")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Backpackers & Guesthouse (Dorms, Private Rooms, Ensuite and Shared Facilities; also campsite options)

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range. Booking.com indicates variable pricing depending on room type and season (typically competitive for Soweto accommodation)

HOSTEL LIST

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: BLAIRGOWRIE

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

ACCOUSTIX LODGE & BACKPACKER

STREET ADDRESS: 477 Jan Smuts Avenue, Blairgowrie, Randburg, Johannesburg, 2194, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.10153,28.01175](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 326 2123](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: accoustix.sleek@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~6.1 – 7.6 / 10

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Lodge
(Mixed dorms and private rooms; shared facilities with communal kitchen)

PRICE RANGE: Beds/dorms: From around R220-R300 per night for dorm beds on independent listings; Private rooms: Typically from ~R470 per night and up.



Province: GAUTENG

Area: EMMARENTIA

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

JOBURG BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 14 Umgwezi Road, Extension 1, Em-marentia, Johannesburg, 2195, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.14713,28.00529](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 888 4742](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@joburgbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Lodge
(Mixed Dormitories, Standard Rooms, Private Rooms – generally a self-catering facility)

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R150 for dorms up to ~R350–R480 for private / ensuite rooms.



Province: GAUTENG

Area: MABONENG

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

CURIOCITY BACKPACKERS JOHANNESBURG

STREET ADDRESS: 302 Fox St, Maboneng, Johannesburg, 2094

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.20396,28.06142](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 614 0163](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 66 162 6915](#)

EMAIL: stay@curiocityjoburg.com

WEBSITE: curiocity.africa

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.8 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Design-Led Backpackers & Social Hotel (Dorms, Female-only Dorms, Private Rooms, and Lofts).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. Dorms: From R320 – R380 per person; Private Rooms: From R850 – R1250 per room.

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: RANDBURG

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

EXPLORER BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 27 7th Street, Parkhurst, Johannesburg, 2193, Gauteng

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.14226,28.01721](#)

PHONE: [+27 71 137 0207](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 71 137 0207](#)

EMAIL: bookings@explorerbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: explorerbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Modern Social Hostel (Mixed Dorms, Female-only Dorms, and Private Queen Rooms with en-suite or shared facilities).

PRICE RANGE: Mid-range Budget. Dorms: From R300 – R370 per person; Private Rooms: From R800 – R950 per room.

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: PARKTOWN NORTH

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

ROSEBANK BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 219 Jan Smuts Avenue, Parktown North, Johannesburg, 2193

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.14196,28.03533](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 447 7445](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 74 628 2222](#)

EMAIL: rosebankbackpacker@gmail.com

WEBSITE: rosebanklodgeandbackpacker.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~5.1 / 10 ("Fair")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Hostel & Boarding House (Dorms, Single/Twin/Double rooms with shared or private facilities).

PRICE RANGE: Low Budget. Dorms: From R190 – R260 per person; Private Rooms: From R450 – R650 per room.

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: GAUTENG

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

BACKPACKERS CONNECTION

STREET ADDRESS: 16 Beech Avenue, Highway Gardens, Edenvale, Johannesburg, 1609, Gauteng

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.10576,28.30718](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 452 4272](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 454 2948](#)

EMAIL: info@backpackersconnection.co.za

WEBSITE: backpackersconnection.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.9 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Airport Budget Hostel & Lodge (Dorms, Twin, Double, and Family Rooms with shared or en-suite options).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. Dorms: From R240 – R300 per person; Private Rooms: From R580 – R780 per room.

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: OBSERVATORY

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

BROWN SUGAR BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 75 Observatory Avenue, Observatory
Ext 1, Johannesburg, 2198, Gauteng

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.18015,28.08591](#)

PHONE: [+27 83 377 9529](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 377 9529](#)

EMAIL: info@brownsugarbackpackers.com

WEBSITE: brownsugarbackpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A (Not listed on this platform).

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Hostel & Lodge
(Dorms, Private Log Cabins, and En-suite Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. Dorms: From R250 per person; Private Cabins (Shared Bath): From R440 – R600 per room; En-suite Private Rooms: From R660 – R1,200 per room.

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: BRAMLEY VIEW

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

GEMINI BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 10 Gidani Road (formerly 10 Bezuidenhout Street), Bruma, Johannesburg, 2198, Gauteng

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.11692,28.1029](#)

PHONE: [+27 11 615 0192](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 453 6610](#)

EMAIL: info@geminibackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: geminibackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~7.5 / 10 ("Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Hostel & Lodge (Dorms, Private Rooms, and Self-Catering Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget.

Dorms: From R240 – R300 per person; Private Rooms (Shared Bath): From R500 – R650 per room; En-suite Rooms: From R750 – R950 per room.

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BACKPACKING ACCOMMODATION

Province: GAUTENG

Area: LOMBARDY WEST

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

MIKASA SUKASA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 5 Russel Road, Lombardy West, Johannesburg, 2090, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.11767,28.11095](#)

PHONE: [+27 65 373 7592](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 65 373 7592](#)

EMAIL: mikajasukasabp@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers (Mixed Dormitories, Female-only Dorms, and Private Rooms)

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R175–R220 for dorms; ~R450–R600 for private rooms (varies by season).

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: KEMPTON PARK

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

TERRYLINN BACKPACKERS HOSTEL

STREET ADDRESS: 2 Halifax Street, Rhodesfield, Kempton Park, 1619, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.12084,28.23438](#)

PHONE: [+27 84 081 8508](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 081 8508](#)

EMAIL: terrylin@mweb.co.za

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars (Based on public reviews for Terrylin Backpackers)

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Airport Backpackers & Guesthouse (Mixed Dormitories, Twin Rooms, Double Rooms, and Family Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R250–R320 for dorms; ~R550–R850 for private rooms (varies significantly by season and proximity to flight demand).

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: KEMPTON PARK

City/Town: JOHANNESBURG

LAKEVIEW BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 39 Porto Amelia Avenue, Bonaero Park, Kempton Park, 1622, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.11985,28.26796](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 491 5344](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 491 5344](#)

EMAIL: roneldutoit@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: Lakeview Backpackers does not maintain a consistent standalone listing on Booking.com; it is often overshadowed by the nearby "Lakeview Boutique Hotel," which is a separate, more expensive facility.

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Airport Backpackers (Mixed Dormitories, Single, Double, and Twin Private Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R180–R250 for dorms; ~R350–R500 for private rooms (varies by demand and season).

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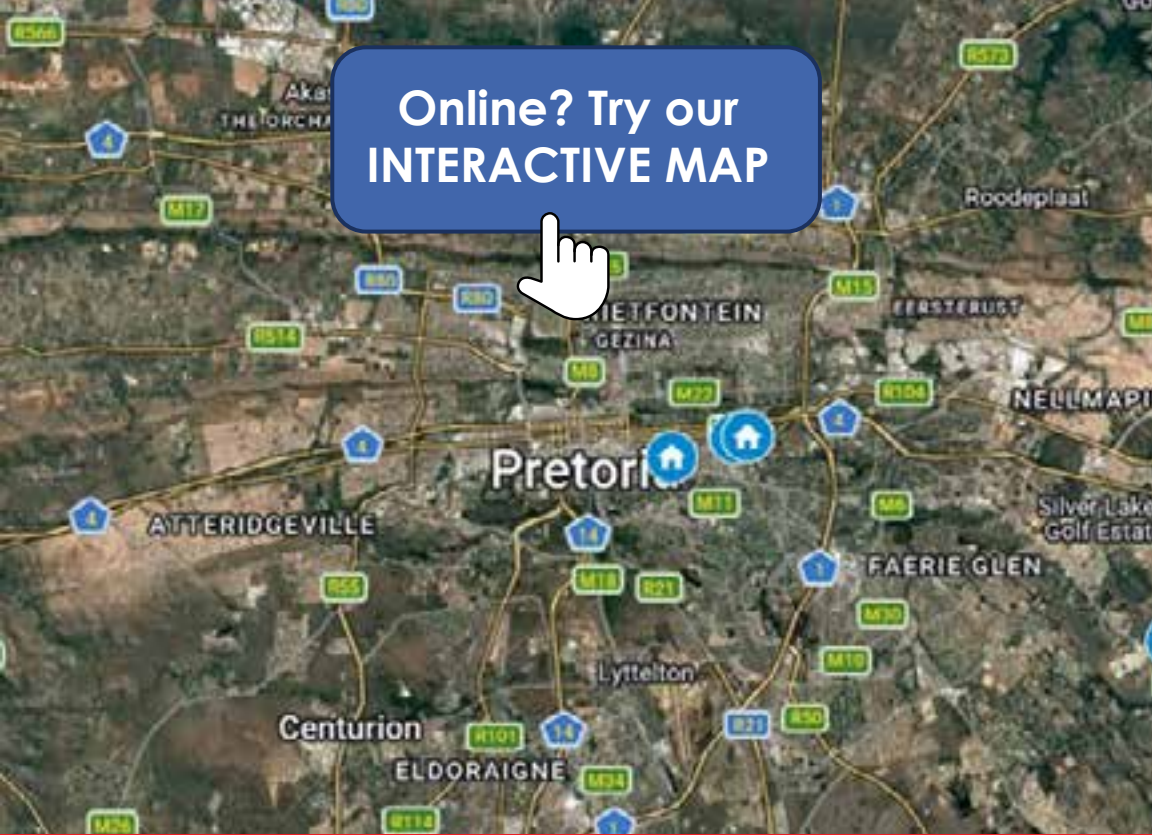
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BACKPACKING PRETORIA

Pretoria is defined by its measured, administrative atmosphere and its extraordinary seasonal transformation. Between late September and November, roughly 70,000 jacaranda trees bloom, turning the entire city violet. This “purple canopy” creates a unique urban environment, best viewed from the Union Buildings—Herbert Baker’s sandstone masterpiece that sits on a ridge overlooking the executive capital. The city’s geography is slower and more residential than nearby Johannesburg, offering a sense of scale and quietude.

History and Culture

Founded in 1855, the city’s character is deeply rooted in Afrikaner history and the Voortrekker legacy. This is most visible at the Voortrekker Monument, a massive granite

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edifice commemorating the 19th-century pioneers. Directly across the valley sits Freedom Park, a memorial to those who died for liberation. This deliberate visual conversation between the two sites allows visitors to engage with the contradictory narratives and historical complexities that define the modern South African identity.

City Geography and Lifestyle

The city operates on a hub-and-spoke system:

Hatfield: The primary backpacker and student hub, home to the University of Pretoria and the high-security embassy row.

Brooklyn & Menlo Park: Affluent eastern suburbs known for upscale shopping and artisanal food markets.

The CBD: The historic heart, featuring Church Square and the Palace of Justice, where Nelson Mandela stood trial.

The South: Home to the Voortrekker Monument and the Groenkloof Nature Reserve.

The lifestyle is distinctly multilingual, with Afrikaans, English, and Sotho-Tswana languages blending in a city that serves as a global diplomatic crossroads.

Social Reality and Inequality

Pretoria reflects the nation's social reality through its starkly different neighbourhoods and contested naming (Pretoria vs. Tshwane). While the embassy districts are heavily policed and affluent, they sit in close proximity to townships like Mamelodi. Visitors are advised to move with attention rather than guilt, supporting community-led tours and local businesses to better understand the city's ongoing process of transformation and reconciliation.



Backpacker Essentials

Best Time to Visit: October is the essential month for the jacaranda bloom. The shoulder months of September and November offer excellent weather with fewer crowds.

Budget: Pretoria is one of the most affordable cities in South Africa. The Gautrain, local dining, and excellent hostels in Hatfield represent exceptional value for those with euros or pounds.

Safety: While generally safer than Johannesburg, situational awareness is key. Sunnyside is a designated no-go zone due to high crime rates. Visitors are advised to stay within the Hatfield/Brooklyn node, avoid independent wandering in the CBD at night, and use Uber for all nocturnal transport.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Pretoria](#)



PRETORIA

- [TOM'S BACKPACKERS](#)
- [PRETORIA BACKPACKERS](#)
- [1322 BACKPACKERS INTERNATIONAL](#)
- [PUMBAS BACKPACKERS](#)
- [TWANA BACKPACKERS LODGE](#)



Province: GAUTENG

Area: HENNOPSRIVER

City/Town: PRETORIA

TOM'S BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Farm 147 Hennopsriver, Centurion, Pretoria, 0157, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.82716,27.97345](#)

PHONE: [+27 82 893 1291](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 82 893 1291](#)

EMAIL: tomsbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.2 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: Tom's Backpackers does not maintain a current active listing on Booking.com; it functions more as a niche group venue and shoestring hostel.

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Eco-Backpackers & Party Venue (Mixed Dormitories, Family Units, and Basic Self-Catering Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Shoestring Budget. ~R240 per person for dorms; family units from ~R1,920 (varies based on group size and event bookings).

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: CLYDESDALE

City/Town: PRETORIA

PRETORIA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 425 Farenden Street, Clydesdale, Pretoria, 0002, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.75282,28.22026](#)

PHONE: [+27 12 343 9754](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@pretoriabackpackers.net

WEBSITE: pretoriabackpackers.net

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Boutique Backpackers & Lodge (Mixed Dormitories, Private Twin/Double Rooms, and En-suite units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R250 for dorms; ~R600 for private rooms (varies by room type and season).

VIBE-METER: 60% Leafy Embassy Retreat / 40% Quiet Academic Base — more of a calm, residential house-share feel than a high-energy traveller hub.



Province: GAUTENG

Area: HATFIELD

City/Town: PRETORIA

1322 BACKPACKERS INTERNATIONAL

STREET ADDRESS: 1322 Arcadia Street, Hatfield, Pretoria, 0083, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.7468,28.24574](#)

PHONE: [+27 12 362 3905](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 643 9444](#)

EMAIL: reception@1322backpackers.com

WEBSITE: 1322backpackers.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.3 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.3 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers (Mixed Dormitories, Female-only Dorms, Themed Private Rooms, and Family Units).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R290 per person for dorms; ~R580–R850 for private rooms (varies by room type and season).

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: HATFIELD

City/Town: PRETORIA

PUMBAS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 1232 Arcadia Street, Hatfield, Pretoria, 0028, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.74706,28.24165](#)

PHONE: [+27 12 362 5343](#)

WHATSAPP: N/A

EMAIL: info@pumbas.co.za

WEBSITE: pumbas.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.0 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers (Mixed Dormitories, Private Garden Cabins, and Standard Private Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Shoestring Budget. ~R150–R200 for dorms; ~R450–R550 for private garden cabins (noted as some of the most affordable rates in Hatfield).

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Province: GAUTENG

Area: ZWAVELPOORT

City/Town: PRETORIA

TWANA BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Plot 42, Boschkop Road, Shere, Pretoria, 0036, Gauteng, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.80848,28.38818](#)

PHONE: [+27 12 817 2009](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 60 926 6293](#)

EMAIL: twanaadventure@gmail.com

WEBSITE: twana.nl

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.2 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Overland Backpackers & Safari Lodge (Dormitories, Wooden Cottages, En-suite Rooms, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range.

Dorms: ~R270 per person; Wooden Cottages: ~R380–R480; En-suite Rooms: ~R450–R550; Camping: ~R220 per person (varies by season).

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with the Afrikaner “Voortrekker” roots of Potchefstroom, the first permanent European settlement in the Transvaal. Sun City adds a layer of political surrealism, built during the apartheid era as a gambling and entertainment hub outside the state’s moral prohibitions. This creates a cultural landscape where deep-rooted tradition meets high-concept commercial escapism.

City Geography and Lifestyle

The province’s attractions are concentrated in the north-eastern “tourist triangle”:

Pilanesberg: A malaria-free Big Five reserve set within a 1.3-billion-year-old alkaline ring complex.

Sun City: A sprawling resort complex featuring the man-made “Valley of the Waves” and the Palace of the Lost City.

The Magaliesberg: An ancient mountain range popular for canopy tours, hiking, and its proximity to the Hartbeespoort Dam.

Potchefstroom: A southern university town defined by student energy, sports, and historic Dutch Reformed architecture.

The lifestyle is primarily geared toward self-drive exploration and outdoor adventure, though the thin hostel infrastructure means most travellers base themselves in rural lodges or university hubs.

Social Reality and Inequality

Inequality is starkly visible in the province’s mining centres and resort boundaries. Platinum-rich Rustenburg faces the social challenges typical of South African mining towns, while the history of Operation Genesis—which



resettled local communities to create Pilanesberg—is a reminder of the contested nature of conservation. The text suggests that visitors should engage with this history through community-based operators to gain a more authentic understanding of the region.

Backpacker Essentials

Best Time to Visit: Winter (May–August) is best for wildlife sightings as vegetation thins. The shoulder months (April–May and September–October) offer the most comfortable weather for hiking and resort visits.

Budget: While dorm beds are inexpensive, activities such as the Valley of the Waves (€24) and Canopy Tours (€37) are mid-range expenses. Hiring a car from Johannesburg or Lanseria is an essential logistical cost.

Safety: Rustenburg and Potchefstroom require standard urban precautions. In Pilanesberg, safety is wildlife-related; visitors must strictly obey park rules and stay in their vehicles. Hodge Podge and Paljas are the primary, if basic, budget accommodation options.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking North West](#)



Province: NORTH WEST

Area: NORTH WEST

City/Town: POTCHEFSTROOM

PALJAS BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 22 Esselen Street, Cachet Bult Park,
Potchefstroom, 2531, North West, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.69607,27.09326](#)

PHONE: [+27 72 429 2914](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 72 429 2914](#)

EMAIL: N/A

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~2.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~2.9 / 10 ("Very Poor")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Basic Budget Backpackers & Inn (4-Bed Mixed Dormitories, Single, Twin, Double, and Family Rooms).

PRICE RANGE: Shoestring Budget. ~R200 for dorms; ~R285–R380 for private rooms (varies by room type and season).



Province: NORTH WEST

Area: NORTH WEST

City/Town: RUSTENBURG

HODGE PODGE BACKPACKER LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: Plot 66, Kommiesdrift, Olifantsnek, Rustenburg, 0300, North West, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-25.77618,27.24361](#)

PHONE: [+27 74 049 2917](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 84 079 4877](#)

EMAIL: antoINETte@magaliesburgbackpackers.co.za

WEBSITE: hodgepodgebackpackers.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.8 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Nature-focused Backpackers & Group Venue (Mixed Dormitories, Private Wooden Cabins, Luxury Family Rooms, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R250 for dorms; ~R500–R650 for private rooms; ~R150 for camping (varies by unit type and group size).

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NORTH WEST PROVINCE

North West Province is a vast, largely agricultural expanse that stretches from the edge of Gauteng to the Botswana border. While much of the landscape is flat, it is punctuated by three extraordinary features: the ancient, eroded volcano of Pilanesberg, the surreal man-made oasis of Sun City, and the Magaliesberg—one of the oldest mountain ranges on Earth. At 2.3 billion years old, these quartzite ridges represent a geological scale that dwarfs the Himalayas, creating a rugged backdrop for the province's diverse bushveld.

History and Culture

The province's identity is a blend of ancient heritage and modern "regulatory arbitrage." The history of the Bakgatla-ba-Kgafela people at Pilanesberg contrasts

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ern arts and outdoor hub. The region maintains a distinct weekly rhythm, shifting from peaceful seclusion during the week to a bustling atmosphere on weekends when visitors arrive from Johannesburg. This evolution is visible in the local sandstone architecture and the growth of independent galleries and craft breweries. Unlike the better-known national parks, the area remains a “local secret” that prioritises quiet exploration, hiking, and the observation of unique natural phenomena over commercial tourism.

Regional Geography and Lifestyle

The backpacker experience is centred on several key locations:

Clarens: A walkable village of sandstone buildings, serving as the primary hub for galleries, dining, and craft beer.

Golden Gate Highlands National Park: A 340-square-kilometre park dedicated to hiking and landscape photography rather than Big Five game viewing.

Clarens Village Conservancy: A protected mountain area immediately adjoining the town, offering accessible hiking trails on foot.

The Ash River: A northern watercourse that attracts visitors interested in white-water rafting and fishing.

Social Reality and Inequality

The region exhibits a significant racial and economic divide, with business ownership and the tourist demographic being almost entirely white. In contrast, the service staff in kitchens, galleries, and guesthouses are primarily Black and Coloured South Africans from the surrounding townships of Kgubetswana and Assegaai. This



pattern reflects broader national inequalities, and the text emphasises that direct, generous tipping is an important practice for travellers to support the local workforce within this specific economic context.

Backpacker Essentials

Best Time to Visit: Autumn (March–May) offers the best combination of amber scenery and mild weather. Winter is clear but extremely cold, while spring (September) is the peak for wildflowers.

Budget: The region is mid-range; a restaurant lunch costs between €10 and €15, though backpacker dorms remain affordable at roughly €10–€12.50. Hiking in the local conservancy is free, while national park day fees are approximately R252.

Safety: While crime is exceptionally low, the primary risks are environmental. Rapid mountain thunderstorms and sub-zero winter temperatures require proper gear. Additionally, driving after dark is dangerous due to the high risk of colliding with livestock or large game on the roads.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Free State](#)



Province: FREE STATE

Area: MALUTI MOUNTAINS

City/Town: KESTELL

KARMA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 2 Piet Retief Street, Kestell, 9860, Free State, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.31098,28.69908](#)

PHONE: [+27 58 653 1433](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 83 442 3973](#)

EMAIL: kestellkarma@gmail.com

WEBSITE: karmalodge.co.za

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.7 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.0 / 10 ("Wonderful")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed Dormitories, Double Rooms, Family Rooms – maximum 17 guests).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R250 for dorms; ~R550 for private double rooms.

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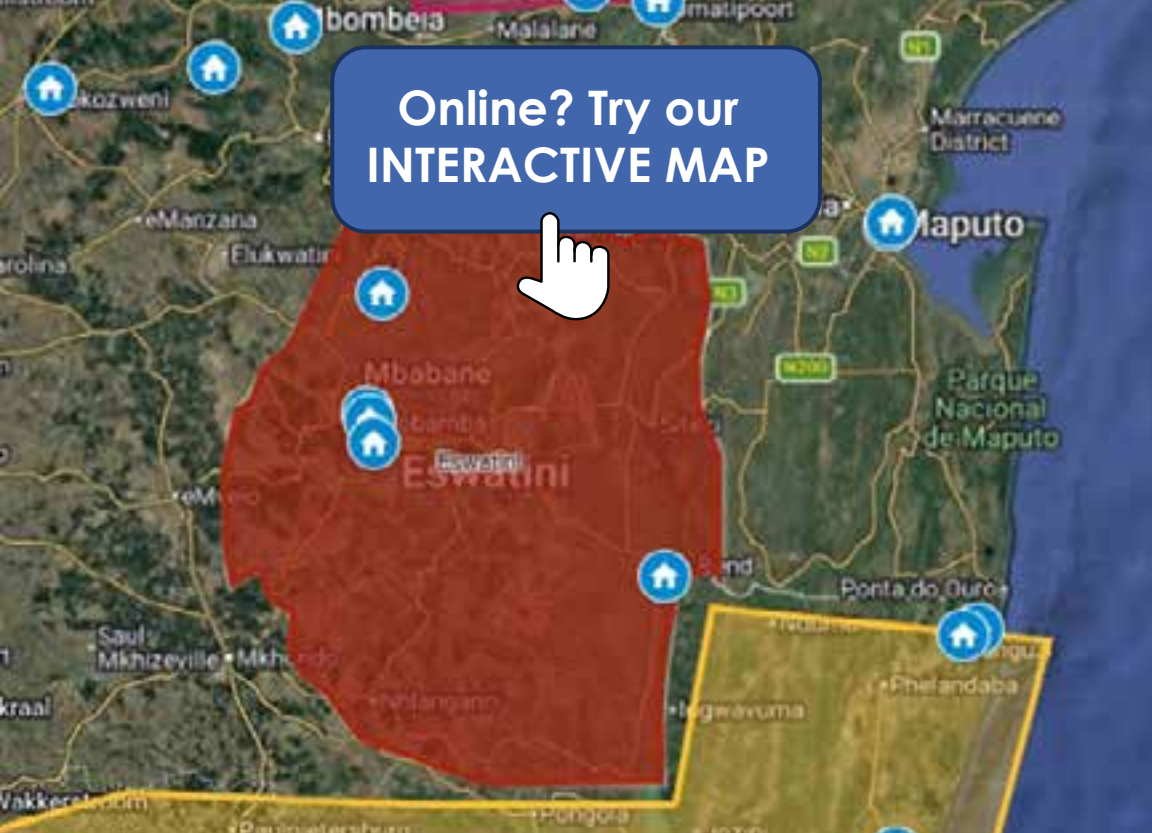
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BACKPACKING ESWATINI

Eswatini is a small, landlocked kingdom nestled between South Africa and Mozambique. Despite its size, it offers a dramatic shift in atmosphere and landscape, moving from misty mountains in the west to subtropical midveld and the eastern Lubombo plateau.

Key Regions and Destinations

Mbabane: The cool, green capital city. It is highly walkable, featuring a functional commercial centre and craft stalls without the intense urban pressure of larger regional neighbours.

The Ezulwini Valley: Known as the “valley of heaven,” this is Eswatini’s cultural and tourist heartland. It houses the royal palace, parliament, and the highest concentration of hostels and restaurants.



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BACKPACKING THE FREE STATE

The Free State is a vast highveld plateau covering 130,000 square kilometres of flat grasslands and agricultural fields. While most of the province is characterised by maize farms and sunflower crops, the eastern corner provides a dramatic landscape shift where the plateau meets the Maluti Mountains. Here, the flat plains end abruptly, replaced by spectacular amber and gold sandstone cliffs. The Golden Gate Highlands National Park is the visual focal point, defined by its 20-storey sandstone formations and a unique quality of light that transforms the terrain into a high-altitude wilderness.

History and Culture

The cultural identity of the eastern Free State is shaped by a transition from traditional farming roots to a mod-

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Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary: Located in the Ezulwini Valley, it allows visitors to explore among plains game on foot, horseback, or bicycle.

The Lowveld: Home to Hlane Royal National Park (Big Five viewing) and Mkhaya Game Reserve (specialising in rhino conservation).

Culture and Monarchy

Eswatini is Africa's last absolute monarchy. In 2018, King Mswati III renamed the country from Swaziland to its indigenous name. While the political system is unique and often debated internationally, the monarchy remains a central symbol of Swazi identity. Major cultural events like the Umhlanga Reed Dance and Incwala ceremony are genuine expressions of a heritage that predates colonial influence.

Practical Information for Travellers

Entry: Major border crossings include Oshoek/Ngwenya (from Johannesburg) and Golela/Lavumisa (from Durban). Most Western and EU citizens do not require a visa for stays up to 30 days.

Money: The local currency (Lilangeni) is pegged 1:1 to the South African Rand, which is accepted everywhere.

Transport: The country is ideal for self-driving with well-maintained roads. Minibus taxis (combis) are available between major hubs. Avoid driving at night due to livestock and aggressive local driving.

Safety: Generally safer than South Africa's major cities. Petty crime exists, but standard common sense is usually sufficient.

Health: The lowveld carries a malaria risk, particularly in summer; prophylaxis is recommended for those areas or



when onward-travelling to Mozambique.

Backpacker Accommodation

Most hostels are concentrated in the Ezulwini Valley, providing easy access to landmarks like House on Fire—a unique organic architectural performance venue and sculpture park.

Legends Backpackers Lodge: Centrally located near shopping and craft centres.

Lidwala Backpacker Lodge: Situated on the slopes of Sheba's Breast mountain.

Sondzela Backpackers: Located inside Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary; entry fees are included in the stay.

Entsabeni Backpackers: A smaller farm-based option in the eastern Lubombo District.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Free State](#)



LEGENDS BACKPACKERS LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: MR103, Ezulwini Valley, Eswatini (Located behind the Gables Shopping Centre)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.43975,31.18301](#)

PHONE: [+268 2416 1870](#)

WHATSAPP: [+268 7604 1530](#)

EMAIL: legendsbackpackers@gmail.com

WEBSITE: legends.co.sz

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.8 / 10 ("Fabulous")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Budget Backpackers & Lodge (Mixed Dormitories, Female-only Dormitories, Private En-suite Rooms, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~E200 for camping; ~E300 for dorms; ~E750–E950 for private en-suite rooms (Rates are in Swazi Emalangeni, which is pegged 1:1 to the SA Rand).



LIDWALA BACKPACKER LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: MR103, Ezulwini Valley, Eswatini (Located next to the All Out Africa office)

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.42354,31.17688](#)

PHONE: [+268 2417 1918](#)

WHATSAPP: [+268 7802 4492](#)

EMAIL: info@bp.co.za

WEBSITE: lidwala.co.sz

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

HOSTELWORLD

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~8.4 / 10 ("Very Good")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Eco-Backpackers & Lodge (Mixed Dormitories, Private En-suite Rooms, Safari Tents, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~E180 for camping; ~E280 for dorms; ~E700–E900 for private rooms (Prices in Swazi Emalangeni, 1:1 with SA Rand).



SONDZELA BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary, Ezulwini Valley, Eswatini

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.49522,31.19532](#)

PHONE: [+268 2528 3944](#)

WHATSAPP: [+268 7602 1272](#)

EMAIL: reservations@biggameparks.org

WEBSITE: On biggameparks.org

SOCIAL MEDIA:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.1 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Game Reserve Backpackers (Mixed Dormitories, Private Rondavels, Standard Private Rooms, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-Range. ~E180 for camping; ~E280–E320 for dorms; ~E650–E850 for private rooms/rondavels. (Note: All guests must also pay the Mlilwane conservation entry fee, approx. E70).



ENTSABENI BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: Entsabeni Properties, Big Bend, Lubombo District, Eswatini

GOOGLE MAPS: [-26.81324,31.9751](#)

PHONE: [+268 7604 2226](#)

WHATSAPP: [+268 7604 2226](#)

EMAIL: entsabeni@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.5 / 5 stars (Based on limited legacy reviews).

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Farm-Style Backpackers & Self-Catering (Mixed Dormitories, Private Rooms, and a standalone 2-bedroom cottage).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. ~E250 for dorms; ~E850 for the private cottage (Prices in Swazi Emalange-ni, 1:1 with SA Rand).



Province: FREE STATE

Area: GOLDEN GATE

City/Town: CLARENS

CLARENS INN & BACKPACKERS

STREET ADDRESS: 403 Van Reenen Street, Clarens, 9707, Free State, South Africa

GOOGLE MAPS: [-28.51579,28.4132](#)

PHONE: [+27 58 256 1173](#)

WHATSAPP: [+27 76 369 9283](#)

EMAIL: clarensinn@gmail.com

WEBSITE: N/A

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~3.9 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Mixed Budget Lodging (Dormitory Bunkhouses, Beehive-shaped Huts, Family Chalets, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget. ~R180 for camping; ~R250 for dorms; ~R300–R380 for private huts and en-suite rooms (varies by unit type and season).

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The map shows the Maseru area with various locations marked. A blue callout box with a hand cursor points to the text 'Online? Try our INTERACTIVE MAP'. The map includes labels for Maseru, Mafeteng, Morija, Mankong, and Mochale's Hoek. Other locations visible include Botshabelo, Hobhouse, Dewetsdorp, Wepener, Zaaron, Rouxville, and Cederburg. The map is color-coded with purple and blue areas.

BACKPACKING LESOTHO

Lesotho, known as the “Kingdom in the Sky,” is the only country in the world situated entirely above 1,400 metres. Surrounded completely by South Africa, it is a high-altitude realm of basalt mountains, thin air, and vast, spare landscapes. It is a rewarding but challenging destination that demands patience and preparation.

History and Identity

Moshoeshoe I: The nation's founder was a master diplomat who built a mountain fortress at Thaba Bosiu in the 19th century. He preserved his people's sovereignty through strategic alliances and military intelligence during the turbulent Mfecane period.

Shweshwe: This iconic indigo-printed fabric, now central to Southern African fashion, is named after King Mo-

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shoeshoe. It originated as a gift from French missionaries and remains a symbol of national identity.

The Basotho: The mountain people of Lesotho have a rich heritage, with highland populations often reflecting the historical absorption of San communities.

Key Activities and Industry

Pony Trekking: The sturdy Basotho pony is the traditional and most effective way to navigate the roadless highlands and experience authentic village life.

Diamonds: Lesotho is home to Letšeng, the world's highest diamond mine. It produces some of the largest and highest-quality Type IIa diamonds ever discovered.

Wildlife and Nature: The country is free of malaria. The environment is defined by its dramatic mountain passes, such as the famous Sani Pass, and the Maletsunyane River.

Practical Information for Travellers

Transport: A high-clearance vehicle is strongly recommended for the gravel mountain roads. The Sani Pass requires a 4x4. Public transport consists mainly of minibus taxis (combis) connecting Maseru to larger towns.

Weather: Expect extreme cold and snow in winter (June–August) and afternoon thunderstorms in summer. The shoulder seasons (April–May and September–October) offer the most stable travel conditions.

Money: The local currency (Loti/Maloti) is pegged 1:1 to the South African Rand. Rand is widely accepted, but ensure you have cash before heading into the remote highlands.

Safety: While rural areas are generally very safe, the primary risks are environmental. Mountain weather shifts



rapidly, and river crossings can become dangerous flash floods within hours.

Backpacker Accommodation

Key lodges are often built from local stone and thatch, serving as essential hubs for trekking and rural exploration:

Malealea Lodge: A famous base in the Western Highlands for pony trekking and community projects.

Ramabanta Trading Post: Perched on a cliff overlooking the Makhaleng River.

Semonkong Lodge: Located at 2,200 metres near the Maletsunyane Falls, offering a dorm and traditional rondavels.

ONLINE? Find out more about [backpacking Lesotho](#)

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LESOTHO

City/Town: MALEALEA

MALEALEA LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Main Road, Nr Matelile, Malealea, Mafeteng District, Lesotho

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.82799,27.59992](#)

PHONE: [+266 5883 9646](#) (Lesotho)
[+27 82 552 4215](#) (South Africa)

WHATSAPP: [+266 5323 0295](#) (Lesotho)
[+27 82 552 4215](#) (South Africa)

EMAIL: info@malealealodge.com

WEBSITE: malealealodge.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Booking.com

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: ~9.1 / 10 ("Wonderful")

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Diverse Adventure Lodge (Mixed Dormitories in Basotho huts, Traditional En-suite Rondavels, Forest Huts, Farmhouse Rooms, and Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. ~R185–R200 for camping; ~R275–R330 for Basotho huts/dorms; ~R500–R600 for en-suite rooms (per person sharing).



RAMABANTA TRADING POST ADVENTURES & LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: A3 Road, Ramabanta, Maseru District, Lesotho

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.66628,27.79663](#)

PHONE: [+266 5844 2309](#) or [+266 2234 0202](#)

WHATSAPP: [+266 5844 2309](#)

EMAIL: tradingpostram@leo.co.ls

WEBSITE: ramabantatradingpost.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

BOOKING PLATFORMS:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.4 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: Historic Adventure Lodge & Trading Station (Traditional Basotho Rondavels, En-suite Rooms, and Campsite with backpacker-friendly facilities).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. ~R180–R220 for camping; ~R350 for basic shared accommodation; ~R750–R950 for private en-suite rondavels (Price varies by meal inclusion).



SEMONKONG LODGE

STREET ADDRESS: 1 Riverside Road, Semonkong, Maseru District, Lesotho

GOOGLE MAPS: [-29.84301,28.04366](#)

PHONE: [+266 5888 1021](#)

WHATSAPP: [+266 5888 1021](#)

EMAIL: info@semonkonglodge.com

WEBSITE: semonkonglodge.com

SOCIAL MEDIA:

GOOGLE RATING: ~4.6 / 5 stars

BOOKING.COM RATING: N/A

ACCOMMODATION TYPE: High-Altitude Adventure Lodge (Stone & Thatch En-suite Rooms, Family Cottages, Mixed Dormitories, and Riverside Camping).

PRICE RANGE: Budget to Mid-range. ~R200 for camping; ~R350 for dorms; ~R1,200–R1,800 for private en-suite rooms (Varies by season; check for “Semonkong Special” rates).





Planning a trip shouldn't be harder than the travel itself. Yet, anyone who has ever spent six hours with forty-two browser tabs open knows the struggle: one site has the price, another has the location, a third has a review from 2014, and none of them seem to agree on whether the "free breakfast" is actually just a single piece of dry toast.

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- Have a price update?
- Were we wrong about a hostel's vibe?
- Know a hidden gem we missed?

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